



## PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

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### OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE  
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC  
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 25<sup>th</sup> June, 2025

*The House met at 2.38 p.m.*

[FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN THE  
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, there would be no Roll Call, no Message from the President, no formal Communication from the Speaker. Let us move to the item numbered 5—*Corrections of Votes and Proceedings and Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND  
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we would start with the Votes and Proceedings of Tuesday, 24<sup>th</sup> June, 2025.

Hon Members, page 1...9?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Mr Afriyie?

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, respectfully, permit me to take you to the sixth line under the item numbered 8 with the heading, “Statement by the Speaker”. With your permission I read: “He further indicated that the initiative is a \$1.6 million project—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, which page are you talking about?

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, that is on page 9.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The item numbered 7?

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, it is the item numbered 8 instead, under the mini heading “Statement by the Speaker”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes.

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** All right, so, Mr Speaker, I was reading the sixth line under the item numbered 8 and I read:

“He further indicated that the initiative is a \$1.6 million project that will run for 18 months...”

Mr Speaker, since we are dealing with an official document, I pray that you consider that we write the 18 first in words, then put the number 18 into brackets. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table Office, you may give it a consideration.

Page 10...11?

Yes, Hon Member?

**Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor:** Mr Speaker, I was on my feet earlier, but I could not catch your eye. On page 8, the item numbered 6 under the heading, Communications from the President, the last paragraph reads:

“The Communication further indicated that H.E. the Vice President shall perform the functions of the President during the absence of the President...”

I am not quite sure though, but I want to seek your direction on this, whether this is how it was captured in the “Communication from the Presidency”, or it is the Table Office that has captured it this way.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** How do you expect it to be captured? Because it reads:

“The Communication further indicated that H.E the Vice President shall perform the functions of the President during the absence of the President...”

**Ing Surv Lukutor:** Mr Speaker, I think that it should read:

“...the Vice President shall perform the functions of the President during his absence...”

Sometimes, yes, we repeat these for emphasis, but I feel that not to make it repetitive, we could make it the Vice President.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** As a drafter, this is the best way of putting it.

**Ing Surv Lukutor:** Mr Speaker, this is the best way?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes.

**Ing Surv Lukutor:** I thank you for your direction.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, do you care to know why?

**Ing Surv Lukutor:** Yes, Mr Speaker, we learn every day.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** In issues such as this, there is a rule on using “he” or “she”, particularly when you want to write in a gender-sensitive manner. So, to avoid using “his”, you repeat. That is gender-neutral.

**Ing Surv Lukutor:** Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** You are welcome.

Page 12...14?

Yes, Mr Frank Afriyie?

**Mr Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, just a minor observation. If it pleases you, I would suggest that on page 14, the item numbered 19, the second paragraph, line 4, we *insert* “of”, after Republic. So, it would read, “Government of the Republic of Ghana”. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, the Table Office, kindly take note. Hon Members, page 15... 16?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Leader.

**Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect, on page 16, we have a Motion, the decision, and the Urgent Questions. An important item is missing.

Mr Speaker, the Member of Parliament for Tolon, and First Deputy Minority Whip, Mr Habib Iddrisu, raised a constitutional matter in respect of the decision of the House, and anchored same on Article 104 of the Constitution. This was not ruled upon. It is my view that, this being an important matter, our votes cannot skip same because Mr Speaker, today, we have the media reporting a decision of this House.

2.48 p.m.

Although it was a majority decision, the decision of this House is binding on the Minority. It does not matter; I am used to the jurisprudence of this House. I am not going to pursue a matter which is notoriously known to all of us. But an important matter that arose regarding the constitutionality of the numbers taking the decision—The argument of Alhaji Habib Iddrisu was not to the effect that the “Yes votes” were being challenged, no. But he was raising a fundamental issue regarding the “Yes votes” itself; that the “Yes votes” did not have the required 138 as envisaged by the Constitution and he raised it.

We continue to learn in this Chamber; I recall, soon after the swearing-in, in the *Votes and Proceedings*, some issues were left out, especially dignitaries and some Members raised that this should be captured in the *Votes and Proceedings*.

There were others who felt that it could, as well, be in the *Official Report*. But the argument was made strongly; since these were very essential matters, the *Votes and Proceedings* must capture them.

Mr Speaker, the constitutional matter raised by Alhaji Iddrisu Habib, Member of Parliament for Tolon, and First Deputy Whip of the Minority, is conspicuously missing in the *Votes and Proceedings*. Mr Speaker, this must find expression in the *Votes and Proceedings*. It is a constitutional matter.

I so submit, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister for Education?

**Alhaji Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I have listened to the Minority Leader emphasising a matter of constitutionality raised on the floor of the House by the Hon Member for Tolon. Let me remind him that this House, the Parliament of Ghana, is not the forum for the resolution of constitutional matters. The appropriate forum in law on matters of constitutionality, where there is a breach of the Constitution guided by Article 2 of the 1992 Constitution; for that, the appropriate forum is the Supreme Court of Ghana.

However, I note, that you, Mr Speaker, presided on any matter on the interpretation of our Standing Orders. The powers are vested in you, Mr Speaker, to interpret as you deem fit and appropriate in accordance with law, and not in a matter which is capricious. But

more importantly, Mr Speaker, on any matter of constitutional interpretation, the appropriate forum is not the Parliament of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, *Votes and Proceedings* of yesterday — the Leader has come and I am sure I was holding forth for him, so I may yield to him — Tuesday, 24<sup>th</sup> June, 2025, attendance in the House was 229 Members of Parliament. I agree with the Hon Member for Tolon that, in Article 104 and on the basis of the ruling of the Supreme Court, in *Justice Abdulai v the Attorney-General*, Mr Speaker, you have always guided us on this.

There is a distinction between quorum to do Business and quorum for a decision in Article 104. Mr Speaker, I am surprised he is raising it. Yesterday, in your Report—You are the Chairperson of the Committee. In fact, we should commend you. I have not seen an Appointments Committee Report as comprehensive as what you presented yesterday. If any of you have one since 1993, share it with us.

Mr Speaker, to the extent that back and forth, the Minority Leader is accommodated even to have preliminary and concluding views as part of the Report. So, Mr Speaker, yesterday, they were six Members here and they did not take part in the vote, so why are they interested in the outcome of the vote? Even though they did not take part in the vote, they were counted because they were present here and that is what Article 104 indicates: those present and voting.

They registered their protest where they belong. But memory lane and interesting times, Clerks-at-the-Table will recall that, even post e-Levy, we were not recorded in the *Votes and Proceedings*, including our walkout, which was conspicuous to the Ghanaian people. I still recall, even that day, six of our Members who were present in this Chamber were marked absent. When I drew the attention of the Speaker, if you recall, it was a day where we had Message on the State of the Nation. But the Speaker presided and responded to you appropriately.

There is no breach of the law. This is not the first time Justices of the Supreme Court have been appointed and this is not the first time they have been approved by the House. They were approved with the Minority registered in your Report, Mr Speaker, that they were not taking part in it. In any case, be informed that we have video record of what happened in this House and, on authority, Mr Speaker, we were more than 139. We were more; they can play the video at any time.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, I do not think we should debate this matter, but we can provide solution for the matter, looking at the definition of *Votes and Proceedings* in the Standing Orders:

“*Votes and Proceedings* means the daily publication of the minutes of a sitting of Parliament comprising the record of the attendance of Members

and any decisions of Parliament for each sitting day;”

I would then proceed to ask the Minority Leader what the decision of this House was on the issue raised by Hon Habib Iddrisu to have been captured by the *Votes and Proceedings*.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, first, my respected Colleague, Hon Haruna Iddrisu, the Minister for Education, in responding to the issue I raised in my very humble view, veered off and decided to introduce certain matters, which I believe that, for the purpose of records, I need to respond to.

Mr Speaker, I never said this Parliament is a forum for constitutional interpretation. I never said that.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, I have indicated that I do not want to open debate on this matter, that is why people were on their feet, but I did not grant them the opportunity. So, we will resolve the matter by looking at the definition of *Votes and Proceedings*. I then ask that what then was the decision of this House based on the issue raised by Hon Habib Iddrisu to have been captured by the *Votes and Proceedings*.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect, this is a house of records. To the extent that—I will respond to you and we are not debating. But to the extent that a submission is made and I am right

here, the records must not capture that which is not factual. So, that is why I am spending a minute to address the issue and deal with it. Please, bear with me.

Mr Speaker, again, the preliminary views that were captured were not only mine. The view of the Majority Leader was equally captured, just for the records.

Mr Speaker, now let me come to the issue you raised. You have read out the meaning of *Votes and Proceedings*, and you want my view. At the risk of repeating what you have already read out, let me, for my own purpose, proceed to read the same aloud:

“*Votes and Proceedings* means the daily publication of the minutes of a sitting of Parliament comprising the record of the attendance of Members and any decisions of Parliament for each sitting day”.

Mr Speaker, I did not raise the matter as a matter upon which a decision was made, and if you look at our *Votes and Proceedings*, even Questions that were filed have been recorded. I am only bringing to the attention of the House that the matter that was raised is not part of the record of the *Votes and Proceedings*.

2.58 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if we attempt a narrow interpretation to mean that the *Votes and Proceedings* only captures the decisions made, then, with the greatest respect, we may not be doing justice to the issue. Because we have had the *Votes and*

*Proceedings*, even recording attendance of non-members at Committee sittings.

So, Mr Speaker, upon your own interpretation that you have given, I do not think that the matter I have raised regarding the record of the constitutional issue raised by Alhaji Habib Iddrisu, which issue is not part of the record, is misplaced.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, what is the difference between the *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The *Official Report* captures everything verbatim, but the *Votes and Proceedings* does not. That is the difference.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, may I respond to you. With respect, I will yield to your ruling on the matter I have raised. If it is your ruling that the matter that was raised is not to be captured under the *Votes and Proceedings*, let that ruling enter our records, and I will yield. Because I am contending that to the extent that the matter he raised was a constitutional matter, our *Votes and Proceedings* should capture same as such. I rest my case on that.

Mr Speaker, but if you disagree and that is your ruling, I would yield. I am not here to get into a controversy with you. You are the presiding officer. My contention is that a matter that was raised has not been captured by the *Votes and*

*Proceedings*. If you rule that no, it is not to be captured, I will yield to it. It is as simple as that.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I think that the Minority Leader should be guided by the indications you have given. I think you have already ruled; maybe he is refusing to accept the ruling. The ruling is clearly governed by the definition of the *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*. It is obvious. So, *Votes and Proceedings* is a daily publication of the minutes of a Sitting of Parliament, comprising the records of attendance and decisions. So, that is what has been captured.

In any case, my recollection is that he was not even allowed to raise that issue. The Speaker disallowed the issue. Yes, the Speaker disallowed it. The Speaker asked him what he was doing when he was speaking and asked him to read the relevant Standing Orders to try and draw his attention to the fact that he ought not to have even been on his feet at the time when he, the Speaker, was speaking. So, his attempt to raise the issue was disallowed. So, please, let us proceed.

In any case, whatever it is, the *Hansard*, which is what posterity will look at, definitely captures everything that was said, to the extent that there was no instruction for it to be expunged from the record. So, whatever it is he is trying to achieve has been achieved. I do not even know why he is belabouring the point, because what he said yesterday,



we did not insist that it should be expunged from the record. This is because as far as we were concerned, nothing was going to stop the approval of the seven judges. No matter what the Minority Leader said or did, we had approved them.

As for the numbers, it was obvious that we had the numbers, and they decided not to vote. I want to commend them for not walking out because I understand that they were going to walk out, but they did not walk out. They sat there and did not vote and we voted. We clearly had the numbers to vote. So, let us move on.

The Minority Leader was not even against the individual judges. He likes them. He clearly praised them, saying that they were very erudite, competent and capable, and he believes that they will be able to uphold the rule of law and the Constitution—*[Interruption]*—No.

Mr Speaker, may we proceed with the Business of the day?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, let us make progress. Well, you raised the issue and I want us to have the understanding of it, that if you look at the definition of *Votes and Proceedings*, it states clearly what should be contained in the *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Votes and Proceedings* is quite different from the *Official Report*. So, with that understanding, can we make progress?

Page 17...30—

**Mr Eric Edem Agbana:** Mr Speaker, at page 30, the item numbered 3(xiii), Mr Prince Nkansah Twum is the Director of Finance, not the “Director of Audit” for the Electricity Company of Ghana.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table, cross-check.

Page 31...33?

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 24<sup>th</sup> June, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Friday, 13<sup>th</sup> June, 2025, under correction. Any corrections? Yes?

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, I refer to column 19, paragraph 2, line 5, particularly, I make reference to the “...District Assembly Common Fund (DA CF)...”. That is how it is written over here. I recommend that we delete “Assembly” and insert the plural version of same, “Assemblies”. It has occurred in subsequent paragraphs, so if the Table Office could take note and correct it.

3.08 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well, Clerks-at -the-Table, I direct that you use the constitutional language consequentially for the District Assemblies Common Fund.

Any other corrections?

Hon Members, in the absence of any other corrections, the *Official Report* of

Friday 13<sup>th</sup> June, 2025 as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Yes, Majority Leadership, any indication?

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much. Mr Haruna Iddrisu is here to answer the Urgent Questions.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, it is time for Questions and the Minister for Education is here to provide answers to the Urgent Questions. Hon Minister, you are welcome.

Hon Members, the item numbered 6, Urgent Question, standing in the name of Mr Samuel Atta-Mills, Hon Member for Komenda/Edina/Eguafo/Abirem.

## URGENT QUESTION

### MINISTRY OF EDUCATION

#### Issues Relating to Staff ID Numbers and Payment of some Teachers

**Mr Samuel Atta-Mills (NDC—Komenda/Edina/Eguafo/Abirem):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education, why some teachers do not have staff ID numbers and have not been paid for several months.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister, you have the floor.

**Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP):** Mr Speaker, let me

thank you for the opportunity to respond to Mr Samuel Atta-Mills and to appreciate him because, this matter is burning at the moment at the Ghana Education Service (GES) Headquarters and the Ministry of Education. My understanding was that a group of the recruited teachers under very different leaderships decided to picket at the GES Headquarters, and to assure the House that there was no manhandling of any of them. It is however regrettable that some of our countrymen and women who have subscribed to and are willing to contribute to the training of our citizens as teachers, especially those at the pre-tertiary level, do not have staff numbers, and have not been paid their salaries.

Mr Speaker, they are undergoing some validation of their information in order for us to deal with this problem of ghost names on the payroll. The fact is, the Ministry of Finance in the year 2024 issued financial clearance for the recruitment of teachers. However, the GES was unable to complete the process for the entire recruits to be placed on government payroll prior to the expiration of the financial clearance at the end of the year 2024. The expiration of clearance prior to the completion of the recruitment process, was partly due to delays caused by inconsistencies in Social Security and National Insurance Trust (SSNIT) numbers.

Mr Speaker, if you indulge me, I will explain. There are some who have dates of birth on their national ID cards not consistent with their SSNIT details and

that is important for us because we need to make a policy determination when the person may retire from the public service and we are guided by the information that is shared with us. So, validation became an inescapable necessity and there are also issues of self-reposting by some of the affected teachers in determining where they want to be and not where the GES has directed them to be. Also, there are some inconsistencies with their Ghana Card numbers.

Mr Speaker, our data reveals that a total of 5,643 newly recruited teaching and non-teaching staff do not have their staff IDs. The number consists of 582 teachers recruited from the Colleges of Education for the year 2024 who were unable to complete their salary input process before December 2024. Also, 2,650 teachers were recruited from the universities but could not complete their salary input before the year ended and 298 diploma teachers were recruited but could not complete their salary input process before the year ended December, 2024.

Mr Speaker, additionally 2,113 graduates were recruited and assigned staff IDs but could not complete their salary input process before the year ended. The data validation is very critical especially with the phenomenon of ghost names on our payroll. The GES has completed the data validation and it is only awaiting financial clearance from the Ministry of Finance so that they will be put on the payroll. Mr Speaker, as soon as that is done, we will get them paid.

Thank you.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, this is not a supplementary question. I know that per the protocols, Mr Atta-Mills should finish before we come in. But Mr Speaker, I need your guidance. The Hon Minister, before answering his question, preceded it with a statement, which statement has gained national prominence that has to do with teachers who picketed at the Ministry and were mishandled. In fact, the media is reporting that one of them died as a result of the situation.

Mr Speaker, he volunteered. I just want to ask because, you are a man who believes in the rules and the text. So, I want to ask you whether in view of the statement he has made —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So observe the rules. As soon as he is done with his supplementary question, you can then have the floor.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, that is why I wanted your guidance.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So my guidance is that you need to observe the rules. Let the questioner exhaust his supplementary question, so I can recognise whatever question you want to ask.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, can it then come in as a supplementary? Very well, if that is your pleasure.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Mr Atta-Mills, you have the floor.

**Mr Atta-Mills:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I would like to ask the Hon Minister and let him know that I have two people from my Constituency who work somewhere in the Western Region. They have been teaching for two years and they have offer letters. When I took them to the Ministry, surprisingly, their names were not on the register. How did this happen and what would be the solution?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister, you have the floor.

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, it would be important that I respond to the Minority Leader in order to correct what he has thrown to this House and the public.

Mr Speaker, it is a despicable lie that someone died. I challenge him to produce any dead body that he may have in his possession or the possession of any person. It is a despicable lie, nothing of that sort happened. There was no injury and no hurt.

Mr Speaker, this morning, even before coming to this House, I met with the president of the petitioners by the name Daffour Eric and their concerns noted as follows:

“Despite having received our appointment letters and fulfilling all professional administrative obligations, including assuming our respective posts and performing our duties diligently, a significant number of us have still not been issued staff identification numbers.”

Those were their main concerns. I assured him that it will be addressed as soon as the Minister for Finance issues financial clearance. We intend to recruit as many as 50,000 teachers, which was provided for in the 2025 Budget Statement of the Hon Minister for Finance.

3.18 p.m.

So Mr Speaker, no such thing occurred at the GES or the Ministry.

And then to answer the Hon Sam Mills' question, Mr Speaker, like he said, two years without being on the payroll is probably a product of a fraudulent recruitment; Two years is not possible. For the category of the petitioners that we are dealing with, I know that they got clearance in May. They were supposed to assume office in August but they assumed office in September. It is my prayer that we do not get to the one-year mark before they have their Identity Cards (IDs) and are paid, and that I can assure them that we will do. I have discussed this with the Hon Minister for Finance and he assured me that once the Auditor-General is done with the validation of some data, he would give clearance to many other ministries to do recruitment. About 50,000 teachers will be recruited this year and we will begin the process any moment after the mid-year review of the budget.

I thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Any further supplementary?

**Mr Atta-Mills:** No, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Hon Members, before—Yes, Minority Leader, do you have a supplementary question?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, this is the House of Records and the Minister of Education is a respected member of this House with integrity.

I know that in the exercise of our public duties, there may come a time that we may not have the information. Mr Speaker, the Minister in an unrelated matter decided to volunteer some information to us because he tells us that there was picketing at his Ministry and no manhandling occurred, although it is being alleged. Mr Speaker, we are here as the people's representatives and we are to protect the rights of people. This is the only Chamber where abuses can be discussed, none other. I would therefore be magnanimous on this matter by urging the respected Minister of Education to take this matter up to validate or otherwise to investigate it.

Mr Speaker, those who were there to picket, were pursuing their economic rights; These are far-rights. The Minister could not have possibly seen certain manhandling. But—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader—

Hon Members, Order!

Hon Minority Leader, I refer to Order 88(7) and with the indulgence of the House, if I may read:

“(7) A Member, in asking a Question, shall not

- (a) address the House;
- (b) raise any argument; or
- (c) offer an opinion.”

I will plead with you to operate within the rules.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I shall comply.

But because he raised the matter, I just wanted to give a background to encourage a smooth process of feedback to this House. But, Mr Speaker, I will go by the rules.

Mr Speaker, is it the position of the Hon Minister, that there was picketing at his Ministry by some aggrieved teachers. However, there is no such information to his knowledge that any manhandling occurred or some other untoward action taken place. Would he take it upon himself to pursue this matter, to establish whether or not, indeed, a thing like that occurred, which is yet to come to his attention?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Alhaji Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Proactively, Mr Speaker, as I reported, I was just arriving at the

Ministry of Education when I saw a police vehicle and some group of persons around the GES headquarters. I immediately invited three policemen to my office through my Aide and I engaged them to appreciate what was happening and they drew my attention to the fact that there were recruits who were unhappy about the fact that they have not been paid, having worked for the state for over nine months.

This morning, before I came to this House, as I indicated, Mr Speaker, I met with Darfuor Eric and I will soon share this with the public—we discussed this matter. He indicated to me that they got their clearance in May and they were supposed to start work in August but they commenced work in September. But naturally, by December 31<sup>st</sup>, the clearance which was issued by the Ministry of Finance had lapsed. I only can work with a renewed clearance that is what I am waiting for and let them be assured.

Mr Speaker, as I have assured this House that about 50,000 teachers would be recruited and some 10,000 non-teaching staff would also be recruited; Adequate provision was made for this in the 2025 Budget.

Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Any further supplementary?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Rightly so, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister tells us that, indeed, he engaged some police

officers upon seeing some teachers picketing at his Ministry. He has shared with us what engagement took place. May I know from the Hon Minister whether soon thereafter he had any cause to engage the law enforcement team on site regarding the lawfulness or otherwise of the picketing group?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister?

**Alhaji Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, picketing is lawful and protest is also lawful. We respect fundamental human rights and freedoms; We will uphold them and not tolerate any act of high-handedness by the security agencies that will affect the enjoyment of those freedoms guaranteed under the Constitution.

But the police also have a duty to protect law and order and to protect lawful persons who are working at the GES, and they simply did just that.

Thank you.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** My respected senior Colleague and Minister, on the 23<sup>rd</sup> June, 2025—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is the third supplementary question.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** That is so Mr Speaker. I am within—

On 23<sup>rd</sup> June, 2025, this is what the Report says:

“An incident occurred at the GES headquarters in Accra, where newly

posted teachers picketing over unpaid salaries were forcibly dispersed by personnel from the Ghana Police Service, including a SWAT team. The teachers were demanding payment for salaries that, in some cases, had been outstanding for up to 10 months. It is described that the police action was aggressive, with terms like manhandled and treated like ‘criminals’, used to characterise the treatment of the protesters.”

3.28 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the report also says that the deployment of the SWAT team under the direction of the GES in response to the picketing has become of grave concern. Mr Speaker, what I know that is—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But is that your report? Acknowledge the author. Who wrote it? Is the person at the Majority Side? *[Laughter]*

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** What my Colleagues who are opposite me and are just six months in this Chamber— **[Some Hon Members:** Oh!] should— *[Interruption]*

**Mr Philip Fiifi Buckman:** Give us your source.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, just do the right thing

by indicating the source of your information to the House.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect, if my Colleagues insist— Obviously, this is my fourth term in this House, so I would not pursue a matter— Mr Speaker, I was reading from a news report and I definitely would provide that to fortify myself. I needed to give the Minister the background to it.

In any event, the Minister is the one who introduced the issue of picketing and said—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, with respect, look at the Majority Side and reprimand, but you are looking here and pretending. They will not learn. Mr Speaker, it was the Hon Minister who introduced the subject matter that there was picketing and a reported manhandling; that is what the Minister said. He is my source. *[Interruption]*— No, the Minister introduced it; this is not coming from me.

That is why when we come into this Chamber, we must learn. If we recall, I drew the attention of Mr Speaker that the Minister had raised a preliminary issue preceding his Answer, so I want his guidance. He said I should wait and deal with it as a supplementary question. So, all I am saying is that the Minister himself said there is a reported manhandling of teachers who were picketing and that it is not so. This was the Minister’s statement; it is not mine. So, if they are asking about the source of any—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, we all saw you reading

copiously from your phone, so we are interested in knowing the source of the document that you are reading. It would be unfair to say that the source is the Minister for Education.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, bear with me. If you patiently follow what I am saying—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I have the patience.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect, when our Minister introduced the subject and said there is a reported manhandling of those who picketed, the Hon Member did not ask the Minister to give us the source. He gave us the information, and that is why I drew your attention first. But do not worry, if they want me to read from here, I will read for them.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But you are already reading.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** I was not done. I did not finish.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the Rules are very clear as to what we should do in asking a supplementary question.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, this is on *Graphic Online*. I am reading for you, so take your time. Mr Speaker, I will never misinform this House. The Minister himself—[Interruption]—To my Colleagues, it is not about shouting; this is an important matter. Mr Speaker, the Minister himself introduced a subject

matter that there is a media report and I am quoting the media report. It is *Graphic Online* that has carried the story. *Citi Online* has also carried the same story. So how on earth do they think that a Minority Leader will come and raise an issue when he does not have his source? So, *Graphic Online* has raised the matter. If they are asking for the source, it is *Graphic Online*—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, Hon Minority Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Yes, Mr Speaker?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** What is your supplementary question?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** My supplementary question is simply that in view of this reported manhandling of these teachers who were pursuing their economic rights, will the Minister, upon becoming aware that indeed, it happened, proceed to fully investigate the matter and report to the House?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much. Whatever it is, neither *Graphic Online* nor *Citi Online* reported any incident of death. My Colleague may be relying on some exaggeration of the incident. What the picketers are concerned about is getting onto the payroll and getting paid. And that assurance, Mr Speaker, we gave them, that as soon as a financial clearance is issued by the Minister for



Finance, we will ensure that they are on payroll. To the Hon Minority Leader, there has been no incident of death, unless he is saying that *Graphic Online* or *Citi Online* reported as he earlier claimed. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, supplementary question number four.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I only want the Hon Minister's assurance that having become aware that no less media portals like *Graphic Online* and *Citi Online* having taken this matter up, he will pursue this matter and ensure that those teachers aggrieved of such manhandling are at peace.

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, there is no matter to investigate. The matter to deal with is to assure them that they will be on payroll and have their staff identification (ID).

Mr Speaker, I am happy to note that the teachers of Ghana would be happy because normally the concern of teachers is how to get elevated or promoted from deputy director to director. Accordingly, the President, John Dramani Mahama, has directed that any person who qualifies to be director be given their salary premium and entitlement, even where there is no vacancy of an office in order to not hold deputy directors for 10 or 15 years without promotion. So, the matter of concern is getting them staff IDs and getting them paid. That, we will pursue assiduously, once the Minister for Finance issues the clearance.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Do you have supplementary question number five? *[Laughter]*

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, you can pursue your sarcasm and I will take it [**Some Hon Members:** Ah!] because I am sitting. Mr Speaker, I do not think that the posture this afternoon is most appropriate to the Leader of the Minority. Mr Speaker, do not do this. We know some of these things. There are young men here, so if you choose to use a certain posture to disrespect me, one day, it will come back and haunt you; it is not appropriate. If I have a supplementary question, I will tell you. So, once I am seated and my microphone is off, it is not for you to ask whether I have supplementary question number five.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** What we are doing here is for the good of democracy, Mr Speaker. So, if you want to pursue the path of sarcasm, so be it; it is up to you. I will do my job and I know how difficult this job is, but I will do it and receive all the insults.

3.38 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, I take a great exception to that. We can all look at Order 89(3), which reads:

“Any other Member may be allowed to ask not more than two

Supplementary Questions except that the Majority and Minority Leader or co-leaders may each ask not more than five Supplementary Questions on the substantive Question”.

Therefore, if I am humbly asking if you have a supplementary question number five, that does not mean I am being sarcastic. I am rather operating within the Rules because the rules allow you to ask a supplementary question up to five. Unless, of course, the Rule does not permit you so to do. Then you can take offence for me asking if you have the fifth question. But within the Rules, you can ask up to five questions. And that is exactly what I am asking; I am guided by the rules.

Hon Members, let me acknowledge the presence of our revered visitors in our midst this afternoon. We have the Presbyterian Church of Ghana, Bethel Congregation, led by Rev Richard Amponsah Marfo, minister-in-charge. They are from Abuakwa South and are 68 in number.

*[Congregants of the Bethel Presbyterian Church were acknowledged]*

We also have PRESEC Staff 5 Basic, led by Doreen Addy, a teacher. They are from La-Nkwantanang Madina and 60 in number.

*[Pupils of the PRESEC Staff 5 Basic School were acknowledged]*

We have Madina Demonstration Basic and Special Unit, led by Amarkson

Mac-Daniel, assistant headmaster, La-Nkwantanang Madina. They are 63 in number.

*[Pupils of the Madina Demonstration Basic and Special Unit were acknowledged]*

Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana. May you have a fruitful visit to Parliament of Ghana. You are welcome.

Hon Members, in the absence of any other supplementary questions, can we move to the Question numbered 150 and it is also scheduled for the Minister for Education.

Hon Members, the Question stands in the name of Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, Member of Parliament for Weija-Gbawe.

## ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

### MINISTRY OF EDUCATION

#### **Completion of Stalled GETFund Projects and STEM Schools in Weija-Gbawe Constituency**

**Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija-Gbawe):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education when the following stalled GETFund projects and STEM school in the Weija-Gbawe Constituency will be completed: (i) Gbawe Methodist Basic ‘3’ (ii) St. Jude R/C Basic School (iii) Weija Presbyterian Primary (iv) Gbawe Cluster of Schools fence wall.

**Minister for Education (Alhaji Haruna Iddrisu) (MP):** Mr Speaker, the Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) school within the Weija-Gbawe Constituency was awarded in October 2019 to Messrs Construction Logistics and GR Construction. The project has stalled as a result of funding constraints.

The consultant, at the instruction of the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund), has recently submitted cost to complete estimates for the remaining works. This will aid the allocation of funds to ensure the completion of the project. The Ministry is hopeful that once funds are made available, the project will be completed by the end of the year.

Mr Speaker, a contract awarded in 2019, six years on, there will be cost variations. It is only proper and appropriate that we do an assessment and evaluation of it in order that the contractor does not operate at a loss. A number of these GETFund projects are being reviewed for contractors to be remobilised to the site.

Mr Speaker, Gbawe Methodist Basic '3' is one of the four schools situated within the Gbawe Methodist Cluster of Schools, which collectively have a total enrolment of 2,124 pupils. The school alone has an enrolment of 506 learners: 245 males and 261 females, with 18 teachers. There is currently one GETFund project ongoing in the school, thus, the construction of a 6-Unit classroom block with ancillary facilities. The project was awarded to Messrs Imaani Enterprise Limited and is

currently at a 40 per cent completion rate. The school is currently operating in an old structure, which does not support effective teaching and learning during rainy seasons. We have taken note of the situation and will consider it for completion subject to the availability of funds.

Mr Speaker, subject to availability of funds, Government will consider a new community day school for the Gbawe community.

Mr Speaker, the St Jude R/C Basic School is one of the public basic schools serving the fast-growing Weija community. The school currently has a total enrolment of 577 pupils, made up of 275 boys and 302 girls. The school has one GETFund project ongoing, thus, the construction of a 1-storey 6-unit classroom block comprising three classrooms on the ground floor and three on the upper floor. The project was awarded to Messrs Donsimon O.V Limited in 2019 and is currently at the roofing stage. The project has stalled due to financial constraints. The Ministry through the GETFund has initiated an engagement with the contractor and the consultant to complete the project as soon as possible to serve its intended purpose.

Mr Speaker, as I have indicated, there is no incentive for many of the contractors to complete the work as they may be operating at a loss

Mr Speaker, the two schools on the Weija Presbyterian Primary School Compound have a total student

population of 701, made up of 392 males and 399 females. The school has a 6-unit classroom project being funded by the GETFund. The project was awarded to Messrs Mahu Akyi Co. Ltd. in 2016.

The project has stalled due to funding challenges and this has greatly affected the learners as the school currently operates in insufficient and old structures, while some lessons are held in the uncompleted ground floor of the structure. The Ministry has taken note of this development and will further engage the GETFund to expedite actions to move the contractor back to the site to complete the project to benefit the good people of Weija.

Mr Speaker, 2016 to 2025, the contractor would only, with the escalation in cost of building materials, would be operating at a loss. We are doing an evaluation of it and we would re-award some of it, but contractors who have proven worthy, safe for the cost overrun, would be considered.

Mr Speaker, the Gbawe Cluster of Schools compound hosts seven basic schools with a combined enrolment of 4,112 pupils, made up of 2,007 males and 2,105 females. The school is fenced and gated. The construction of the fence wall was awarded to Messrs Julak General Limited and has been completed with no outstanding payment at GETFund.

Mr Speaker, it is the reason I am assuring the Hon Member that we would prime them for a community day school akin to what was built in Kwabenya, subject to availability of funds, in order

that we provide expanded access to both primary and secondary education.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Any supplementary questions?

**Mr Shaib:** That is all, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister indicated that, subject to the availability of funds, has he got any indication as to when we are receiving funds to have this project fast-tracked?

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, there are about 62 uncompleted projects that are receiving the priority attention of the Ministry. Work would commence on 22 of them this year and we will get them mobilised after the Mid-Year Budget Review.

Mr Speaker, I am making a case for the Ministry of Education to benefit from the Big Push of the President in order that we can expand infrastructure and get some uncompleted projects completed under the Big Push.

In addition, as soon as they GETFund gets additional resources, I will be happy to come back to the House for us to prioritise some of these initiatives.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Any further supplementary?

**Mr Shaib:** Mr Speaker, that is so. I also heard the Minister indicate that 62 are currently receiving attention. I want to know specifically if these projects I

have mentioned, especially the STEM school, is part of the 62.

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, about 10 STEM schools are being prioritised. The future of quality education is on Science, Mathematics, Engineering; that is the STEM. And we have noted that, around the country, we have 5,000 schools which are still under trees. National requirement for junior high school is about 800 school infrastructure. For the Free Senior High School, we necessarily must expand access in order to end the double track with expanded infrastructure. We are working at it, subject to the availability of funding.

**Mr Shaib:** Mr Speaker, I think my question was more specific. My mentor tried to, respectfully, evade the question.

My question was whether or not the STEM school in Weija is part of the 62?

3.48 p.m.

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, the Hon Member is also part of Leadership and I have taken judicial notice of that. But be assured that, as I indicated, Gbawe may even benefit from a new community daycare school. If he has a school which absorbs a population of 4,000, that is very encouraging. For us, it is to expand access to education.

This year, Mr Speaker, the Budget is largely correctional, as he is aware, but I am aware that into the 2026 formula of the GETFund, many of these projects will receive priority attention. I have

already drawn the attention of the Administrator of the GETFund, even to honour the entitlement of Members under the Fund for their education-related project. It is receiving the priority attention of Mr Paul Adjei.

**Mr Shaib:** Mr Speaker, I am grateful.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, thank you very much.

Hon Members, this is a constituency-specific issue; can we move on to the Question numbered 176 which stands in the name of Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni?

### **Status of the New Campus of the Gambaga College of Education**

**Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (NPP — Nalerigu/Gambaga):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education the status of the new campus of the Gambaga College of Education which started in 2016.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

*[Uproar]*

Order! Order!

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I should thank the Hon Member.

Mr Speaker, His Royal Majesty Nayiri, Naa Bohugu Mahami Abdulai Sheriga (Overlord of Mamprugu Traditional Area), the East Mamprusi Municipal Assembly, and the people of

Mamprugu spearheaded the establishment of the Gambaga College of Education as a community college of education in 2012. The College is located in Gambaga in the East Mamprusi Municipality of the North East Region.

Mr Speaker, this weekend, I was in Gambaga with the Hon Member. How I wish he encouraged me for us to visit it. So, maybe, one of these days, we should go back to Gambaga and I will look at it.

Mr Speaker, in 2015, the Government absorbed the college as part of the 46 public Colleges of Education. The College has trained and deployed about 1,726 certified professional teachers who are in classrooms across the country.

Currently, the College has a student enrolment of 1,212 with a staff strength of 98, comprising 38 lecturers and 60 non-teaching staff. The College runs three Bachelor of Education degree programmes namely, Early Grade Education, Primary Education, and Junior High School Education.

Mr Speaker, as part of the efforts of Government to enhance infrastructure in the College, the College acquired a new site for development as its main campus. Accordingly, Government awarded several contracts in 2016 to support the development of the new campus. The construction of a multi-purpose hall was awarded to Messrs Kobbiscan Company Limited.

Currently, no work has been done on the project. Similarly, the construction of the 3-storey Administration Block,

awarded to Messrs Julisam Company Ltd., has also not commenced. The contract for External Works and Drainage Systems was awarded to Messrs Madabu Company Ltd., with only 2 per cent of the work completed so far. A Model School Block awarded to Messrs Vebpo Company Ltd. is at a rate of progress of 12 per cent. Additionally, a 4-storey Hostel Block (Phase I), being undertaken by Messrs Ah-Rauf Company Ltd., is at 16 per cent completion.

Mr Speaker, these projects are part of the several uncompleted GETFund projects across the country due to funding challenges. The Ministry will engage the contractors through GETFund to find an immediate solution to ensure these projects are completed to serve their intended purpose

Mr Speaker, these are from 2016 to 2025 and that is why it is an onerous responsibility for succeeding governments to continue projects initiated by the previous Government in accordance with Article 35(7) of the Constitution. Be assured that the Gambaga Teacher Training College will receive the priority attention of Government.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Hon Minister if he could give some timelines that we should expect— *[Uproar]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Order!

Hon Members, do not push me to mention your name into the record.

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, I am surprised my senior Brother, Hon Suhuyini Alhassan, is leading the charge against me—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, have you asked your question? Hon Minister?

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, the question I want to ask the Hon Minister for Education is that when should the people of Nalerigu/Gambaga Constituency expect a contractor to go back to the site again?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, he knows what the Gambaga Training College means to me and the Government of Ghana. It will receive the priority attention of the Minister. As soon as I am successful in my bid to get additional financing from the Big Push, some allocation will be made for the completion of those projects that have been abandoned since 2016.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Any further question?

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, we know that the Gambaga College of Education is the only college in the entire North East region. If we look at the current campus that they operate from, the previous Government, the Akufo-Addo-Bawumia-led government, added some facilities including dormitory blocks, classroom blocks, fenced the entire

current campus and an Information Technology (IT) centre but still—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, what is your question?

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, I am laying a foundation to ask my question.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Be guided by the rules.

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, the current school still faces some accommodation challenges, both classroom and dormitory accommodation. Is there any plan to add both dormitory and classroom accommodation to the current campus?

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, the Hon Member knows very well that the school remains in the state it was left in 2016, after the exit of the John Dramani Mahama first four-year term Administration. No significant work or additional work or additional contract was awarded for the expansion of the Gambaga Teacher Training College. We note with satisfaction that some 1,700 teachers have benefited from their training. How I wish we could scale that up, even to multiply that by two. That can only be achieved with expanded infrastructure. So, the Hon Member should be assured, they could not, but we will do it for them.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your third supplementary question?

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, I am left with one supplementary question.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is why I said your third supplementary question.

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, with the second supplementary question, my senior Brother did not get the question correct. I am talking of the current place the school operates from—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, on the hindsight, let me read the rules again. Order 88(7) reads:

“A Member, in asking a Question, shall not

- (a) address the House;
- (b) raise any argument; or
- (c) offer an opinion.”

3.58 p.m.

**Alhaji N. M. Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, I am guided, and I trust my senior Brother that he would prioritise the Gambaga College of Education. My final question has to do with the fact that these days it has become very difficult to get admission into the Colleges of Education because of the quota system. I want to find out from the Minister if there are any plans to take out the quota system or increase the quota system of these Colleges of Education for them to do more intake? Thank you very much.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, I believe this question must be a full question to the Minister. Your

question under consideration is to ask the Minister for Education, the status of the new campus of Gambaga College of Education which started in 2016. Now, your supplementary question is on the quota system.

Yes?

**Osahene Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, for those of us who are your Colleagues, if you pinch us to the rule, it is fine but Mr Speaker, these are young men who have just come. I am not saying that you should not get them to comply with the rules. Mr Speaker, but the approach, when you hit them—the Hon Member is not an experienced lawyer like you so, if you say, “the rule says”, Mr Speaker, you get him off guard. Our duty as seniors is to help the young ones. If you do that to me, I do not have a problem. But, Mr Speaker, this is a young man, and it is a constituency-based question.

Mr Speaker, I would therefore encourage the Chair that—Please, these are your children who would one day want to say that you contributed to their grooming. Yes, the Minister can answer the question. He is here. I do not know what Mr Haruna Iddrisu cannot do. The only thing he cannot do is to create a human being. But he is prepared to give some answers. So, Mr Speaker, I am only encouraging you. I am not saying you are out of order, whatever you are saying is within the rules, but I am pleading that these young ones, some of whom have specialised in making noise, we must encourage them with some milk, instead of feeding them with hard *Kenkey* or *Waakye*.



Mr Speaker, I am pleading. If what I have said finds favour with you, so be it. But, if you think that you would not yield to my humble call, Mr Speaker, I cannot say much.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, I am guiding them accordingly. It is for a stated reason that Order 89(1) concluded by saying that:

“...a Supplementary Questions shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question”

Hon Members, the essence is not to take the Minister by surprise. Now, you have brought a Minister here to answer questions based on Gambaga College of Education and you are asking him about the quota system. If you want to ask a question on the quota system, let it be a question to the Minister, to enable the Minister prepare his answers and deliver it on the Floor. So, the essence is not to take the Minister by surprise. That is why I am adverting his mind to the question and the rules. So, if you want to base your last supplementary question on Gambaga College of Education, I would give you the floor.

**Mr Anyimadu- Antwi:** Mr Speaker, as was said by the Minority Leader, I do not know what the Hon Minister for Education cannot answer. The plea, is that, yes, you are 100 per cent right, but if the Hon Minister is prepared to answer, I pray that he be allowed to answer that and then the young one could be cautioned not to repeat that the next time but, I am sure this is something that

is of interest to us all and the Minister has it at his fingertips.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The difficulty I have, is to set a bad precedent. I cannot base it on the ability of the Minister to respond to a question contrary to the rules to set a standard. What if another Minister comes and that Minister is not able to respond to a question of this nature? So, standard rules must be applicable to all the Ministers. Thank you very much. This is also a constituency-specific question. Can we move to question number 177?

Yes, you have one more question?

**Alhaji Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, you ruled on the last one.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Do you want to ask another question?

**Alhaji Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, even after that, someone could also ask another supplementary question.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** No, I said this is a constituency-specific question that you have asked. So, sometimes, for constituency-specific questions, we limit it to the questioner. This is not a general question. So, if you do not have any other supplementary question to ask—

**Alhaji Mumuni:** Mr Speaker, is limiting it to the questioner part of our Standing Orders? I want to learn something from you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, by the practice that I have noted in this House, when you have a lot of Questions, the Speaker has the discretion that once this is a constituency-specific question, we limit it to the questioner. I am not the first speaker to limit the constituency question to the questioner.

**Alhaji Mumuni:** All right. Thank you very much. Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Minister for Education for the answers, and to thank him again for having the Gambaga College of Education at heart, and we are in his hands. We expect him to do something for us in Gambaga College of Education.

Thank you very much.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Question number 177, standing in the name of Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie, MP for Odododiodioo Constituency.

### **Update on the stalled Ayalolo Cluster of Schools Project**

**Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (NDC — Odododiodioo):** Mr Speaker, as a first-timer, I am guided by the advice given in the House. Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education an update on the stalled Ayalolo Cluster of Schools Project in Odododiodioo and the steps being taken to ensure its completion.

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to respond to the question posed by Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie.

Mr Speaker, the Ayalolo Cluster of Schools is located in the Accra Metropolitan Assembly of the Greater Accra Region. The school has a student enrolment of 1,614, comprising 786 males and 828 females. The school has a staff strength of 64 teachers, of which 20 are males and 44 are females.

Mr Speaker, a contract was awarded to Messrs Flexcom MB Limited in 2016 to construct an 18-unit Classroom Block for the school.

Due to financial challenges, the above project has stalled. The GETFund has initiated arrangements with the various consultants to enable contractors to mobilise to the sites. However, the dates for completion of the projects cannot be determined now, but prompt releases of funds from the Ministry of Finance will greatly help to speed up the early completion of these stalled projects.

Mr Speaker, let me assure the Hon Member that I have requested GETFund to prioritise the completion of this project. I thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, any supplementary question?

**Mr Ashie:** Mr Speaker, not on this very one.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. Hon Members, the next question is also a constituency-specific question. I am exercising my discretion under Order 89 not to allow a supplementary question. We then move

to question number 178, also standing in the name of Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie.

### **Update on the Richard Akwei Memorial School Project**

**Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (NDC — Odododiodioo):** Thank you once again, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Education an update on the Richard Akwei Memorial School Project in Odododiodioo, given concerns regarding the structural integrity of the facility and its potential safety risks.

**Mr Haruna Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much. The Richard Akwei Memorial Basic School was founded on 1<sup>st</sup> October, 1930. The school currently has a student population of 1,171 with a staff strength of 26 teachers. The school can boast of 20 classrooms, a library, and a staff room. A three-classroom project was started on 31<sup>st</sup> January, 2020, by Messrs Sparta Cranes and Engineers and is yet to be fully completed.

Mr Speaker, the records from the Ministry could not confirm that the Ministry or any of its agencies awarded this project. However, notwithstanding, the Ministry will engage with the Regional Coordinating Council and the Metropolitan Assembly on the way forward.

Mr Speaker, many of them, as I have indicated, cost escalation is a disincentive to contractors going back to site to get it completed. It is one of the projects the Government will prioritise through the GETFund. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Any supplementary questions?

**Mr Ashie:** No, Mr Speaker. I am grateful to the Minister for Education, and I am very hopeful that soon we will see work done. Thank you very much.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, this brings us to the end of Questions slated to the Minister responsible for Education. On behalf of the House, I want to thank the Minister for attending upon the House and answering the Questions. Hon Minister, thank you very much. You are discharged.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Majority Leader.

4.08 p.m.

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, the Chairman of the Defence and Interior Committee indicated that the Report itemised as 9(c) is ready.

So, if we could vary the Order of Business because the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts was flying in from Kumasi and I was hoping she will be here by this time but she has not arrived yet but the day is still young by our schedule. So, with your indulgence, if we could lay that, after that we will also lay item 9(d). The Chairman of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation is here so he can also lay that. So, Mr Speaker if you will grant our application.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, available leader the application is to vary the Order of Business.

**Mr Shaib:** Mr Speaker we are not opposed to it.

**Mr Frist Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Hon Members we vary the Order of Business. At commencements of Public Business, item numbered nine, Presentation of Papers. 9(c)(i).

## PAPERS

*By the Chairman of the Committee —*

(i) Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the determination of the urgency of the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

**Mr Ayariga:** 9(d) Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** What of 9(c)(ii)?

**Mr Ayariga:** 9(c)(ii), is also ready, Mr Speaker.

*By the Chairman of the Committee —*

(ii) Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Majority Leader?

Yes, Hon Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi?

**Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, I rise to seek your guidance on something small. Mr Speaker, on the public holidays Bill, yesterday when the

Bill was laid, the Leadership of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs was asked to join. I want to find out what time am I as a Ranking Member supposed to have a glimpse of the Report? Is it after it is laid and circulated or I must have a look at the Report before laying?

Mr Speaker, I seek your guidance. I have called the Chairman of the Committee on Defence and Interior. Mr Speaker, more than 10 times this morning just to have a copy of this Report and look but I have not seen a copy of the Report. All I hear is that the Report is being laid and I do not think this is right.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the rules are clear as to how Committees' Reports are to be generated and presented to the House. So, Chairman of the Committee, this is an issue being raised by — So, what is your response?

**Chairman of the Committee on Defence and Interior (Mr James Agalga):** Mr Speaker, with all due deference to my good Friend, my senior at the Bar and the Ranking Member for Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs, I explained to him that this morning as the Chairman of the Defence and Interior Committee, I led my Committee to pay a familiarisation visit to the Ghana Prisons Service at their headquarters and when I returned at about two, there were some minor corrections that needed to be done. In fact, the Chairman of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs actually followed up and together we

went to our secretariat and did the minor corrections.

Mr Speaker, after the corrections, normally they carry the Report to the printing room, bring sufficient copies, bring them to Table and when it is now laid, then the distribution is done. So, I want to apologise to my Friend. It is never my intention to keep this Report away from him.

In any case, it is a three-page, Report. Everything we discussed last night is captured in the Report and he will bear me out when he goes through the Report.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Anyimadu-Antwi?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, there is a proverb in our dialect that says that if your knee is that strong, they break it. The man has already apologised. Where else am I taking it? But it should not happen again, especially when I am chasing him for the Report. I even asked if he had a soft copy. I wanted to peruse through, but it has been laid. We will go through if there is any mistake.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Anyimadu-Antwi, I agree perfectly with you. I have been your Ranking Member. I know sometimes these things are hurting.

Yes, item numbered 9(d) that is ready? We are taking 9(d) instead?

*By the Chairman of the Committee —*

(d) Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Corporate Insolvency and Restructuring Regulations, 2025.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, can we take item numbered 14? But Mr Speaker —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, before we proceed to 14, let us look at our Standing Orders. Order 160(3). Order 160(3) says;

“Where the Committee determines that the Bill is of an urgent nature, the Committee shall inform the House by a report”.

Mr Speaker, if it is just for the information of the House, a Committee having concluded that it is an Urgent Bill, if it is just for the information of the House, how is it that it has to be a motion taken by the House? Because it will place the Committee in a situation where they have concluded and yet this House will vote against the Motion.

4.18 p.m.

We will place the Committee in a situation where they have concluded, and yet this House will vote against the Motion. If the House votes against the Motion, then we will be undermining the authority that our Standing Orders vests in the Committee. So, in my opinion, it is

for the Committee to inform the House that they have concluded that it is an urgent Bill. *[Pause]*

Mr Speaker, I just noticed that the Standing Order says “inform the House”, so I do not know if a matter for information is a matter that we must approve, if their job is just to inform the House.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Let me take the view of Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah, after that I will come to Hon Anyimadu.

Thank you very much.

**Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah:** The Majority Leader wants an academic debate, and this is not the law faculty. Mr Speaker, unfortunately, the combined effect of all the rules applies, and let me refer the Leader to Standing Order 101 on Motions and Amendments. It sets out Motions that ought to be debated, and there are exceptions created here. If we look at the Order Paper, what is captured is a notice of a Motion. Where an exception is created for a Motion not to be debated, it is catered for in the Standing Orders. For example, under Standing Orders 101, “Notice of a Motion”, it reads:

“Notice shall be given of a Motion intended to be moved except a Motion

- (a) for the adoption of the report of the Business Committee...”

It does not include such very important Government Motions which are being originated by a Bill. Bills are very important to the extent that the Supreme Court ruled that we did not even debate certain clauses in the Narcotic Control Act. The Supreme Court struck out some of the provisions that we did not debate and take a vote on.

So, it is very important that such a Bill emanating from the Executive ought to be debated, and it is not part of those Bills or Motions that are exempted under the Rules. That is my response to the Leader.

Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, let me hear the Minister for the Interior.

**Minister for the Interior (Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, that is why I was saying that the Leader was drawing us into an academic exercise in the Chamber. The principle about Committees is that, whatever the Committee does should get to the House. The House can disagree with the Committee. So that is why, if we remember when there was this issue in the Eighth Parliament about the Report of the Committee on Privileges, where there was this argument that once the Committee decides, it should remain there, we argued strongly that whatever any Committee of this House does is just a guide. It is for the House to either agree or disagree.

So, Mr Speaker, even though I am the proponent of this Bill, I would have loved to move it with speed, so that once the Committee agrees, we would not even table it for the possibility of being rejected. But the principle of the House is that, any decision of the Committee is just a guide. It is for the House to take a decision whether to agree or disagree with the Committee.

So, if we look at Article 106(13) of the Constitution, it is what has been reproduced verbatim into Standing Order 160(2). But it does not preclude the processes of the House. It is there for them to inform us that they have seen that this is of an urgent nature. The House will then say that since the Committee is advising on that, we agree or disagree with the logic. The House could either make the Committee go back, or disagree completely with the Committee.

So, Mr Speaker, I want to submit that for the Committee of the House, regardless of the assignment given them—That is why if we look at—even if it is an emergency, for instance, with the Finance Committee, the Constitution says that if the House is on recess, they will take a decision and when the House is in session, they will come and report. This is because anything that is done at the Committee is just a guide for the House to enable the House to take a decision.

Mr Speaker, I believe that how we have been running this is right, and we probably should not introduce new things that may create difficulties in the future.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Hon Members, Article 106(13) says that:

“Where it is determined by a committee of Parliament appointed for the purpose that a particular bill is of an urgent nature, the provisions of the preceding clauses of this article, other than clause (1) and paragraph (a) of clause (2) shall not apply, and accordingly, the President shall give his assent to the bill on its presentation for assent.”

Hon Members, the Constitution says the Committee shall make a determination. Now, the issue that we have to resolve is whether or not the determination of the Committee should be subjected to parliamentary approval. So, once the Constitution empowers the Committee to make a determination, can this House do otherwise? That is the issue that we have to address.

Now, a textualist may look at it and say that the Committee’s determination is all right, but does the Committee’s determination bind the entire House? Why is the Committee giving information to the House? For the House to do what with the information given by the Committee? Majority Leader, you will have a stake in it, but let me pick the thought of Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah.

**Mr Boamah:** Mr Speaker, I was going through the *Votes and*

*Proceedings*, and I believe that yesterday the Hon Minister for the Interior was in the House, and he presented a Paper on behalf of the Government. And I do not know if you were the one presiding, I think it was the Rt Hon Speaker. He said he was referring this urgent matter to the Joint Committees of Interior and Defence, and the Leadership of the Constitutional and Legal Affairs, to go and sit on the matter and report.

That presupposes that the House, the Plenary, has the final say. And this is not the first time an urgent matter has been brought to the Floor for a debate. So it is very important that we stick to the known rules and procedures of approving urgent matters by the Government. The Committee is a Committee of the House.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I do not have a problem with that. Previously, what we had been doing is that, once the Committee makes a determination, the reports of the urgency and the Committee's Reports were put together, and then the Bill was slated for second reading. But now, the report on the determination of the urgency is separated from the main Committee's Report on the Bill.

Hon Anyimadu, I will come to you.

**Mr Anyimadu:** Mr Speaker, as you have rightly said, the closest we have come to, and especially from the last Parliament, was if we had to decide on the urgency, and the matter was of an urgent nature, we tried to fuse the report together, but we reported to the House that this is what the Committee had done.

And we assumed that the House would go with us, and then we would take the two reports together. That is what we had done in the past.

But specifically, yesterday, when the Bill was laid, the Speaker directed us to report on the urgent nature of the Bill. And that is why, Mr Speaker, in the Committee's wisdom, we decided to submit two reports. Thank you.

4.28 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** We would go by that.

Yes, Hon Member? I would come to you, Alhaji Suhuyini Alhassan.

**Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah:** Mr Speaker, this is a very interesting academic debate you have invited us to deliberate upon but I would respectfully, not look at Article 106 in isolation. I would want us to consider Article 106 together with 103, being the work of Committees of this House.

Mr Speaker, when we look at the work of Committees, they do not take away the work of the Plenary, which is the work of this House. There is no express provision of the Constitution that says that when the Committees are done with its work, there will be no debate. There is nothing like that.

Mr Speaker, when we look at the Constitution, together with the Standing Orders, in terms of law-making, when the Committee is done with its work, they are referred to the House for a



debate. In that regard, it may well seem that the information which is being given to us is for the purposes of debate for us to approve of whatever Bill is before us.

Mr Speaker, when we look at Article 106, we will discover that the essence of the subject matter, which is being discussed, is to suspend certain protocols that would ordinarily precede ordinary Bills which are introduced to the House. But that does not include debate. So, very respectfully, in the absence of an express provision in the Constitution which takes away our power to debate on Bills before same being approved, it may be, very respectfully, unconstitutional to say that, simply because a Committee has deliberated upon it and presented its Report to the House, it is only for information and not for debate.

Mr Speaker, very respectfully, I think that if we go along those lines, it will be problematic in the sense that it may potentially lead to an absurdity. The absurdity being that, we are likely to see a lot of Bills being brought to the House under a certificate of urgency.

Mr Speaker, when it so happens, that could be the way by which debates are precluded or excluded from taking place in this House and that can be serious. So, in my humble opinion, going along the lines of the argument of the distinguished Majority Leader may lead to an absurdity and I do not think it is going to augur well for this House.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Alhaji Suhuyini Alhassan?

**Deputy Minister for Roads and Highways (Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan) (MP):** Mr Speaker, thank you very much, for the opportunity to contribute to this interesting intellectual discussion that the Majority Leader has deliberately introduced as we consider the Reports of the Committees.

Mr Speaker, I think this discussion began yesterday when the former Minister for Defence requested the Speaker to guide the House on whether or not the Report had to come for us to decide on the urgency of the request of the Minister for the Interior before we look at approving it.

Mr Speaker, if we recall, yesterday, after the intervention by the former Minister for Defence, I sought to get guidance from the Speaker, because, like the Hon Member said earlier, in the past, what has been the practice is that Committees come with one Report in which they state the urgency of their request and then go ahead to give or recommend approval for the matter that is requested by the Minister in question.

But, yesterday, the Speaker was clear: he directed that the Committee should decide on the urgency first and submit to the House for consideration before they look at whether or not the House will approve the request of Government.

Mr Speaker, I think that the question of what to do with the first consideration when it is reported is quite dicey. If we look at Article 106(6) of the 1992 Constitution, Mr Speaker, it relates to

Bills, but for the purpose of this conversation, I think it is relevant for me to make reference to that. Article 106(6) says:

“The report of the committee, together with the explanatory memorandum to the bill, shall form the basis for a full debate on the bill for its passage, with or without amendments, or its rejection, by Parliament.”

So, Article 106(6) relates to a Bill, but it also talks about a Report of a Committee and it directs what be done when a committee presents a Report: we debate and do not make amendments to it, but we take a decision. It is in that same light that I will argue that the Report is not just for the sake of information; it is for a decision to be made on the recommendation of the Committee.

Mr Speaker, however, going through the Standing Orders, I noticed under Order 114 that there is a way that, perhaps, a Committee can come through the Speaker and the urgency will be decided by the Speaker. Once that agency is decided by the Speaker, the Committee may just have to go and submit a Report.

Mr Speaker, Order 114(3),

“That in determining whether a matter should have urgent consideration, the Speaker shall consider...”

Mr Speaker, with your permission, if there is time, I will read Order 114(3)(a),

(b), and (c). If there is no time, then I will leave it to you to guide us as to whether my thinking is right that we can come under this Order 114 for the Speaker to determine the urgency for us before even a Committee goes to consider the request of a Minister.

Thank you very much.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

Majority Leader, I think we should end the debate and continue some other day. So, you may, probably, have to start from the Motion numbered 14. Other than that, there will be another argument as to whether the Bill being introduced under a certificate of urgency which the Rule says it may be taken through all stages in one day; we need to move a procedural Motion. That is another conversation.

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I think I just drew your attention to a language that we have, for the past over two decades, taken for granted. Because if you read Article 106(13), it is clear: where it is determined by a committee of Parliament appointed for the purpose that a particular Bill is of an urgent nature, the provisions of the preceding clauses shall apply.

Mr Speaker, it is obvious that the Constitution intends that the determination is made by a Committee. Also, Order 284 of our Standing Orders make provision for Committees to take decisions by voting. So, we vote at the Committee level to take a decision whether it is

urgent and if the vote passes at the Committee level, then we now report to the House that it is an urgent Bill and the House has no capacity to say that it is not an urgent Bill. But Mr Speaker, I think that we have been practising this for a while now, so let us move.

I am getting the indication from you that we should proceed to take the Report and continue. If we take the Report, then of course, the items numbered 16 and 18 will no longer apply. Because once we take the Report and make a determination that it is an urgent Bill, then all the Motions requiring abridgement of time no longer become necessary because the substantive provisions no longer apply in the passage of this Bill.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. That is why I said that is another consideration. So, we are going by what Mr Anyimadu-Antwi said, unless he wants to depart from your earlier decision.

4.38 p.m.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** What the Majority Leader said, since he would want us to be academic—Mr Speaker, if you look at our rules, Order 160, and I would not say the specifics, but let us go to Order 160(5) and with your permission, I read:

“Where the Committee determines that the Bill is not of an urgent nature, the Committee shall report that determination to the House and the relevant provisions of the Constitution and these Orders shall apply.”

What shall apply? It means that when we report at the House and a decision is taken, that this is not of an urgent nature, then the Bill would have to go back to be *gazetted*. So, this House needs to take a decision on it, either for or against it. That is why we have made an earlier Report, on the urgency of— So, I pray that we take that Report first.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, this is a house of records. The Leader of the House has made a statement and he says that where a Committee takes a decision, the subject matter of an urgent referral, same is binding upon the Plenary. Mr Speaker, this jurisprudence, with all due respect, is rather very difficult to see a legal elasticity.

Mr Speaker, how can a Committee of Parliament oust the jurisdiction or the mandate of the Plenary of Parliament? It is never ever in the contemplation of the laws governing Parliament and it can never be in the contemplation of any law governing any serious Parliament anywhere in the world, that a Committee would have its decision binding on Plenary.

Mr Speaker, at the risk of repeating what Hon Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka had earlier said, when the matter of Adwoa Sarfo came up, the argument of the Leader of the House was to the effect that once the decision has been made, what it means is that the House is bound, because the Constitution does not expressly mention the Plenary; it mentions the Committee. Mr Speaker, the Rt Hon

Speaker in ruling on this matter disagreed with the textual approach to that interpretation that it was very limited.

Mr Speaker, Hon Patrick Boamah, a moment ago, referred to the situation where we refer to all the rules that govern our processes and proceedings in this House. So, Mr Speaker, I just want *Hansard* to record me as having said that the strange proposal from the Leader of the House cannot be seen to be meeting our expectation in terms of the precedence we know and the very jurisprudence that has governed this House. A Committee of Parliament cannot have its decision binding on Plenary. I so submit and I want that to be the record.

If for any reason there is any provision anywhere in our laws which suggests that, Mr Speaker, I beg to say that should never receive the blessing of this House.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the Motion numbered 14 at page 4 of the Order Paper of today.

Yes, Chairman of the Committee, you may move the Motion numbered 14.

## MOTIONS

### Suspension of Order 104(1)

**Chairman of the Committee (Mr James Agalga):** Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders

which requires that a motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the determination of the urgency of the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be *moved* today.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the Motion has been moved, any seconder?

**Deputy Ranking Member of the Committee (Mr Kofi Amankwa-Manu):** Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

*Question put and Motion agreed to.*

*Resolved accordingly.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we will move to the item numbered 15—Motion.

Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

### Report on the Determination of the Urgency of the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025

**Chairman of the Committee (Mr James Agalga):** Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the determination of the urgency of the

## Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

In so doing, Mr Speaker, I shall present the Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior.

Mr Speaker, I would entreat the *Hansard* to capture the Report in its entirety while I present only the highlights.

### 1.0 Introduction

The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025 was presented to Parliament and read the First time by the Hon Minister for the Interior, Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka, on Tuesday, 24<sup>th</sup> June, 2025, in accordance with Article 106 of the 1992 Constitution and Order 159 of the Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana.

The Bill was subsequently referred to the Committee on Defence and Interior and the leadership of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs for consideration and report in accordance with Article 106(4) and (5) and Orders 247 and 165 of the Standing Orders of the House. The Hon Speaker, in accordance with Article 106(13) and Order 160(2), also directed the Committee to determine whether the Bill is of an urgent nature to be taken through all the stages in a day.

Pursuant to the referral, the Committee met with the Hon Minister for the Interior, Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka, and officials of the Ministry of the Interior, and the Attorney-General's Department and considered the referral.

The Committee, having carefully examined the referral, hereby presents this Report to the House in accordance with Article 106(5) and Orders 166 and 215 of the Standing Orders of the House.

The Committee is grateful to the Hon Minister and Officials of the Ministry of the Interior and the Attorney-General's Department for attending upon it and assisting in the deliberations.

### 2.0 Reference

The Committee referred to the following additional documents during its deliberations:

- The 1992 Constitution of Ghana;
- The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana; and
- The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001 (Act 601).

### 3.0 Background

The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001 (Act 601) establishes the statutory framework for the declaration and observation of public holidays and commemorative days in Ghana. As the nation has progressed, the list of public holidays and commemorative days and the method of observance of these holidays have evolved to reflect national priorities and values of the time.

The proposed amendments to Act 601 intend to revise the existing holidays

and commemorative days, introduce new holidays and empower the President to declare the Mondays immediately after a Saturday or a Sunday, or the Fridays immediately following a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday as public holidays. The amendments are therefore intended to promote nationalism, reinstate historical integrity and also promote international best practices in the observation of public holidays. It further seeks to promote national unity and religious impartiality in the country.

The proposed amendment is also in line with the government overall agenda and promise to overhaul the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days regime to ensure equity and the preservation of the nation's history.

There is therefore the need to revise the statutory framework of the holidays and commemorative days observed in the country to reflect the country's values and history. The revision is also meant to ensure religious equity, inclusivity and national development.

#### **4.0 Purpose of the Bill**

The purpose of the proposed amendment to the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001 (Act 601) seeks to:

- a. Introduce an additional holiday, namely the Shaqq day, to be observed a day immediately following the Eid- ul-Fitr holiday each year;

- b. Recognise the transition of the country to a republican status in 1960 and provide for the observance of Republic Day on the 1<sup>st</sup> of July as a public holiday and not as a commemorative day;
- c. Provide for the removal of the celebration of Founder's Day on 4<sup>th</sup> August as a public holiday and rename Kwame Nkrumah Memorial Day as Founders' Day which is to be celebrated on 21<sup>st</sup> September;
- d. Empower the President to, by Executive Instrument, declare the Monday immediately after a Saturday or a Sunday, or the Friday immediately following a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday to be observed as a public holiday where the holiday falls on a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday other than a religious holiday.

#### **5.0 Provisions of the Bill**

The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025 is divided into Two Clauses and Two Schedules.

Clause 1 of the Bill seeks to amend section 3 of Act 601 to empower the President to, by Executive Instrument, declare any other day to be observed as a public holiday instead of a day provided under section 1 of Act 601 where the President is satisfied that it would be inexpedient to observe that day as a public holiday. The clause also

empowers the President to, by Executive Instrument, declare a public holiday to be observed on the Monday immediately before a Tuesday, a Wednesday or on Thursday, or on the Friday immediately following a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday, where the public holiday falls on a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday. Under the clause, where a public holiday falls on a Saturday or a Sunday, the President is empowered to, by Executive Instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Monday immediately after that Saturday or Sunday, or on the Friday immediately before that Saturday or Sunday

Clause 2 amends section 7 of Act 601 by adding on to the definitions of expressions used in the Bill. The First Schedule to Act 601 is amended under clause 3 to expand the list of public holidays by the inclusion of Shaqq Day and Republic Day in the list of public holidays and commemorative days.

The First Schedule to Act 601 is amended under clause 3 to expand the list of public holidays by the inclusion of Shaqq Day and Republic Day in the list of public holidays. The Republic Day was previously observed as a commemorative day. The amendment also revises the name of the Worker's Day holiday to "Labour Day", removes the celebration of Founder's Day on 4<sup>th</sup> August as a public holiday and renames Kwame Nkrumah Memorial Day as Founders' Day which is to be celebrated on 21<sup>st</sup> September.

Under clause 4, the Second Schedule to Act 601 is amended by the removal of

Republic Day from the list of commemorative days, leaving African Union Day (25<sup>th</sup> May) as the only commemorative day.

## **6.0 Justification for the Amendments**

The proposed amendments are justified by the need to reform the country's holiday framework in a manner that is inclusive, historically accurate, promotes productivity and makes the holidays regime responsive to evolving social and cultural dynamics of the country and globally.

## **7.0 Observations**

The Committee, having examined the Bill, made the following observations:

### **7.1 Urgency of the Bill**

Following the presentation of the Bill, the Rt Hon Speaker directed the Committee to determine the urgency of the Bill. The Committee subsequently met and unanimously determined the Bill to be of an urgent nature to be taken through all the stages in one day in accordance with Article 106 (13) of the Constitution and Order 160 (3&4) of the Standing Orders of the House.

The House subsequently adopted the Report of the Committee on the urgent nature of the Bill.

### **7.2 Promote International Best Practices**

The Committee observed that the proposed amendments which seeks to

empower the president to declare mid-week holidays (except religious holidays) to be celebrated on the Monday or Friday will enhance productivity, reduce disruptions to the work week, reduce absenteeism and promote a better work-life balance.

### **7.3 Religious Equity and Inclusivity**

The Committee noted that the proposed amendment reflects an effort to promote religious equity in the country by ensuring balanced recognition of diverse religious practices, thereby avoiding partiality toward specific religious groups in the celebration of religious holidays. The introduction of the “Shaqq Day” as a public holiday will allow Muslims who travel to their home regions for the annual Eid celebration to travel back to their various work regions.

### **7.4 Financial Impacts Analysis**

The Committee was informed that the implementation of the proposed Public Holidays (Amendment) Bill, 2025 will not require significant additional resources from the State. The additional holiday is expected to increase consumer spending as holidays can boost household spending, particularly in the tourism and hospitality sectors. The Hon Minister informed the Committee that people often take vacations, travel to visit family and friends, or engage in leisure activities, leading to increased demand for goods and services. Again, additional and longer holidays will help in job creation with retail, hospitality and creative arts industries hiring seasonal

workers to meet growing demand for services during holidays.

The Committee further noted that public holidays have the potential to stimulate tourism and associated industries, including creative art services, cultural, natural (environmental), restaurants, transport services, accommodation providers, and retail services. The creative arts industry would also greatly benefit from such long holidays. Additional and longer holidays will stimulate household spending and accelerate economic growth.

## **8.0 Amendments**

The Committee, after its deliberations proposed the following amendments to the Bill:

- i. Clause 1 – Amendment proposed – sub-clause (2), Delete and replace with

“(2) Where a public holiday provided under section 1 is to be observed on a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday, the President may, by Executive Instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Friday immediately following the Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday”.

- ii. Clause 1 – Amendment proposed – sub-clause (3), Delete and replace with

“(2) Where a public holiday provided under section 1 falls on a Saturday or a Sunday, the



President may, by executive instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Monday immediately after the Saturday or Sunday”.

- iii. Clause 3 – Amendment proposed – Delete “Farmer’s Day” and substitute with “Farmers’ Day”.

## 9.0 Conclusion

Mr Speaker, the Committee has thoroughly examined the Bill and is convinced that the proposed Bill aims at ensuring that the existing framework for public holidays is fair and consistent with best practices.

The Committee, therefore, recommends to the House to adopt this Report and pass the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025 in accordance with Article 106(13) of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana and Order 160 of the Standing Orders of the House.

The Hon Minister for the Interior informed the Committee that the next envisaged holiday under the Bill is eight days from today, that is on 1<sup>st</sup> July, 2025. The day is earmarked for the observance of Republic Day as a public holiday. Notwithstanding the significance of the republican status of Ghana, the day is presently celebrated as a commemorative day. The Government, therefore, intends to amend the existing arrangement to declare the day as a public holiday to allow all Ghanaians to actively participate in the activities of Republic Day.

4.48 p.m.

The Committee unanimously recommends to the House to adopt this report in accordance with Article 106 (13) of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana and Order 160 of the Standing Orders.

I respectfully move.

*Question proposed.*

**Ranking Member of the Committee (Mr Kofi Amankwa-Manu):** Mr Speaker, I beg to support the Motion ably made by the Chairman for the Committee on Defence and Interior. But Mr Speaker, one thing I find a bit disturbing is that from 7<sup>th</sup> January, 2025, we knew that 1<sup>st</sup> July would come. Looking at the Report, this obviously was a campaign promise; a promise that needed to be fulfilled. So, what I find a bit interesting is why we sat all this while only to rush in with this Bill. It is something which I find very disturbing.

Mr Speaker, I believe that going forward, we do not need to sit, rush with the Bill, only to get Members to pass it. That will not augur well for this House. Mr Speaker, with these few words, I once again support the Motion made by the Chairman of the Committee.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

**Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin):** Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for the Interior is seeking an urgent amendment to the

Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act 2001, (Act 601) under a certificate of urgency.

At the outset of my own views on this matter, let me make it clear that we do not trivialise Ghana's heritage or the importance of inclusive celebrations. However, we must question Government's sense of priority in according a certificate of urgency to a Bill about public holidays.

Mr Speaker, with our country facing serious socio-economic challenges and unfulfilled reform promises, this push to fast-track a holiday amendment is frankly perplexing. It gives the impression that the resetting of the calendar, as we were told, has been taken to a point where the resetting of the economy and governance is merely a symbolism and the Government is not in any way determined to rescue us.

Mr Speaker, certificate of urgency is an extraordinary tool intended for critical time-sensitive legislation, typically reserved for matters of national security, economic emergency or dire public need. We in the Minority find it difficult to accept that tinkering with public holidays meets this threshold. What exactly is the emergency, Mr Speaker? By rushing this Bill, Government implies that declaring new holidays or renaming existing ones is as urgent as tackling, say, an epidemic or financial crisis.

Mr Speaker, looking at the promises that the Government made, I have a tall list of them, our friends in the National Democratic Congress (NDC) made

promises on their campaign platforms of social intervention and they termed it that they were resetting Ghana. Ghanaians were promised some sweeping changes that will require urgent critical attention. Yet, after six months, the changes that we expect remain unfulfilled.

Mr Speaker, the Government promised that the Ghanaian Family Values Bill, 2021 will be pursued. Mr Speaker, it has been six months. Our Friends then in opposition used the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill, 2021 as a major campaign tool. They made strong public declarations in support of its passage. They staged press conferences, issued statements, and gave Ghanaians every assurance that they were committed to defending family values and enacting the Bill into law. In fact, some of the loudest voices championing the Bill came from this very House on their Side. But today, when they have the power to act, when they have the mandate and the numbers, the same people have gone mute. There is no government-sponsored Bill, no clear position, no timeline and no urgency. Where is the principle? Only silence. This is not just disappointing, but we see it as deliberate.

They are coming here with an urgent Bill. What has happened to that the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill, 2021? They told Ghanaians that they are against this surge of the Lesbians, Gays, Bisexuals, Transgenders and Queers (LGBTQ), so they would enact a law. Now we see people kissing at the Independence Square and it is on social media. Men are practising it and it is all over. We are not seeing urgency

there. Mr Speaker, this is the same Government, when in opposition talked about this and then the only urgent Bill the Minister for the Interior brings is that he wants to now amend the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001 (Act 601). Why?

Mr Speaker, there is no action on *galamsey*. We were told that *galamsey* will be tackled as a national emergency. Yes. We are telling them that there are other urgent matters that we need to bring to this House. Mr Speaker, equally disturbing is Government's failure to act decisively against illegal mining. In opposition, the NDC promised a ruthless war against the *galamsey* menace that is ravaging our beloved country. They campaigned on protecting the environment, ending illegal mining and even suggested they will introduce new laws, a possible *galamsey* ban Bill — they spoke about it — or at least revoke policies that enable mining in protected areas. Ghanaians took them by their word, but in power, these promises have proven to be mere rhetoric.

To date, the Government has not introduced any comprehensive legislation to outlaw or severely restrict illegal mining. There is no *galamsey* ban Bill before this House, despite the crisis of poisoned rivers and destroyed forests. Mr Speaker, even more egregiously, the Government has refused to repeal the law. There is no repeal. The Legislative Instrument (L.I.) 2462, which they promised to repeal, has still not come to this House.

So, I am questioning whether or not Government is acting in good faith. What is so urgent about this Bill? Mr Speaker, I give you another one. They promised the domestic worker's Bill. They promised property rights of spouses' Bill.

4.58 p.m.

They promised a new scholarship scheme law.

Mr Speaker, all of these have not featured.

**Mr Mahama Ayariga** — *rose* —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, let me recognise the Majority Leader.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, very well.

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, it is trite rule in this House; very basic rule, that a Member shall not be reading in the Chamber. It is clear; it is in our rules, that a Member shall not be reading copiously. Even first-timers know this rule. [*Hear! Hear!*] But since yesterday, I have observed that the Minority Leader has been reading copiously from written notes. Where it is coming from, I do not know. And the extent to which he is glued to what he is reading, tells you that it may not have been written by himself.

Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader must depart from this act. We are to debate. If you have objections to the urgency of the Bill, debate it. But do not be reading a Statement on the floor of

this House. I am not even going to talk about relevance. I am just saying that he should stick to the basic rules—That he should debate and not be reading copiously in this Chamber. I mean, at his level as the Minority Leader, that he comes here and he is always reading copiously.

Mr Speaker, he should comply with the rules of this House.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, are you reading or referring to your notes? *[Laughter]*

Please proceed.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I will not attempt to respond to my very respected senior and Leader of the House. But what I have to say is very simple. In all the serious democracies that I know, Members, are encouraged to prepare and keep to the substance. It is only in our jurisdiction. If you go to the United Kingdom (UK), I have been there, he has travelled there. If you go to the United States of America (USA), India—Check, you must prepare because these *extempore* submissions we make, sometimes you go into *Hansard* and you realise that your thoughts are entangling here and there.

Mr Speaker, our rule did not say, do not come with your prepared notes. The rule cannot be interpreted to suit the Majority Leader when he knew I was on a firm ground. He uses this to come and shake. But I will not be shaken by this.

Mr Speaker, I will proceed.

Mr Speaker, I have been in that seat before.

Mr Speaker, the Government promised to review import taxes and provide auto industry support. Mr Speaker, the Government promised to review these taxes, reduce taxes on industrial and agricultural input within 90 days. And specifically, to scrap the ban on importing salvage vehicles that has hurt local artisans at Suame Market at Suame Magazine and Kokompe.

What has the Government done about it?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, may I respectfully urge upon you to base it on the subject matter before us.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** That is exactly what I am doing.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is, determining the urgency or otherwise.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, let me lay the foundation. It is my contention that the Government bringing this Bill under a certificate of urgency is being brought in bad faith and it is selective in terms of its priorities. I am giving reasons I hold that view. That is why I am saying that they have made promises on other Bills they consider urgent. And I am wondering why those have not been prioritised. Like the anti-*galamsey* one; they have not brought it. Why this one?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, I am just urging upon you to chart a righteous cause.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, that is what I am doing. Mr Speaker, they promised the Conflict of Interest and Anti-Corruption Bill. They have not brought it. They said that was very urgent. Today they are in power and they have not brought it. The NDC's own manifesto promised, "... to introduce conflict of interest legislation as part of restoring good governance".

Mr Speaker, where is that Bill if they really mean to reset the country? Why have they not introduced it? Why have they gone quiet on it?

Mr Speaker, the Intestate Succession Amendment Law, they also promised that they would treat it as an urgent Bill. Today, we have spousal right issues. The long-awaited reform that they promised. They have not brought any legislation. And then all of a sudden, as if matters have suddenly arisen, the Minister for the Interior comes here to say that we should consider this Holiday Amendment Bill under certificate of urgency.

The Government is not prioritising their own promise of one job, three shifts—24-Hour Economy. They have not brought the Bill to this House. Where is the Bill on 24-Hour Economy? The President in his State of the Nation Address (SONA) promised that the Minister for Finance will introduce it during the Budget hearing. When he submitted the Budget Statement, this was conspicuously missing. To date, we do

not have the 24-Hour Economy Bill. Where is it? That is a Bill that would have created jobs, as you promised. One job, three shifts. Many of our youth are not getting jobs. They have not prioritised it and then they come here and say holiday, holiday, holiday. They are interested in holiday, holiday, holiday. The urgency they consider is holiday, holiday, holiday.

A government that does not prioritise job creation. A government that does not keep its promises. Contractors are not being paid. Releases are not being made to Ministries. Ministers are here and they have not received their releases. That is not urgent but holiday, holiday, holiday. They are not prioritising releases to the various agencies under his Ministry.

The Minister for the Interior has not come here with a Bill to introduce reforms under the various agencies under his Ministry. All he comes—Under certificates of urgency—holiday, holiday, holiday. *Nye taa shia, nye taa shia, nye kayaaa nitsumo, nye taa shia*. Stay at home, do not go to work. This is the urgency that the Minister is considering.

Mr Speaker, without prejudice to the Report that is before us, I have made my point, they are in Government, if the Majority, after taking the people's mandate, will not consider bringing the anti-LGBT law here; they will not prioritise the anti-*galamsey* Bill that they themselves promised; they will not bring the 24-Hour Economy Bill, and they want to prioritise holiday, holiday, holiday. Go ahead and do it. We are not part of it.

Mr Speaker, I so submit.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Majority Leader?

5.08 p.m.

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I am surprised that the Minority Leader would be so vociferous against this particular Bill, because this particular Bill affects all the Muslims in this country. [*Hear! Hear!*]**—**Mr Speaker, I am surprised that he has so voiced his opposition to treating such a Bill with this level of urgency that this Side of the House wants to give it. We promised Muslims in this country that we will give an additional holiday, and this Bill is to fulfil that promise. And it is obvious that the Minority Leader is against it. He is against it, and I am surprised. How could he be opposed to Muslims being given an additional holiday? Hon Afenyo-Markin, how could you be opposed to Muslims? One additional holiday to Muslims, and you are opposed with this level of vehemence? And you have Muslims in your constituency who queued to vote for you. Please, withdraw your opposition to this Bill. This Bill is to fulfil the promise to Muslims, to give them an additional holiday. [*Uproar*]

So Mr Speaker, the Committee has given a clear indication that it is urgent, and we have debated the Report. I think you should put the question, and let us move on.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Minority Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader is completely out of order. [*Uproar*]**—**Mr Speaker, I stood on a point of order.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But you do not have the right to rule anybody out of order.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I am not ruling. I am premising my argument on that. Mr Speaker, when the Majority Leader got up, he did not have a point of his own. What he sought to do was to invoke political mischief and I would explain the reason to the House.

My submission was to the effect that Government should prioritise its economic and social promises to the people, and that the prioritisation of the promises they made should have been long pursued. I again proceeded to argue that the issue of holiday has not suddenly arisen. He cannot therefore just get up to bring a Bill.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for the Interior cannot just get up and bring a Bill and say that we should consider it under the certificate of urgency. What he is doing is in bad faith because there were other promises that they made. Why are they not keeping it?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, you have made those points.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, he stood up on a point of order and you listened to him.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But what is your point of order?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, what was his point of order? [*Uproar*]—Mr Speaker, that is becoming one too many. It is when it gets to me that your interjections come. Do not do this. When he was doing the mischief, you could have intervened to tell him that what he was doing was wrong, but you were listening. So, I am intervening to make my point clear that I am against their sidestepping all the socio-economic promises that require urgency. They have failed to bring that one and they sat and came so late to claim that they are coming under certificate of urgency. I am against their coming under certificate of urgency at this late hour, because a government must prioritise. What they are doing lacks priority, and that is a point I have made.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, his point of order was based on the Rules that you were reading copiously. [*Laughter*]—That is why I am asking you, what is your point of order?

*Question put and Motion agreed to*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, can we take the Motion numbered 17?

Yes, Minister for the Interior.

## **BILL — SECOND READING**

### **Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025**

**Minister for Interior (Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka) (MP):**  
Thank you very much Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025, be now read a Second time.

Mr Speaker, in doing this, I just want to say that we have looked at the number of holidays that we have, and we have gone through them, and as a new Government, having in mind some of the promises that we made with regard to the holidays, have restructured the holidays to take away those that in our view, were controversial, so that we keep those that we as a country are unanimous on and rally around.

Mr Speaker, we are keeping 1<sup>st</sup> January as New Year Day; 7<sup>th</sup> January as Constitutional Day; 6<sup>th</sup> March as Independence Day; March or April for Good Friday for our Christian brothers; March or April as Easter Monday for our Christian brothers; 1<sup>st</sup> May as Labour Day; and 1<sup>st</sup> July as Republic Day. Republic Day was pushed as a commemorative day, but we believe that this is a very significant day in the life of Ghana that we should not just relegate to the background. Therefore, we are

bringing it back as a full holiday, and we believe that as a country, we are united around the 1<sup>st</sup> July. We have taken out 4<sup>th</sup> August as then being termed as Founders' Day, because we believe that as a country, we are not unanimous around it, and it serves as a divisive day for us as Ghanaians. So, we have taken that out, and we have maintained the 21<sup>st</sup> September which we will now term as the Founder's Day. It is the date of birth or the birthday of Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah, the founder of our country, the one who led us into independence. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, there is no doubt in our country—Yes, we know that there is no way one can say they went to a fight and carried the fight alone. One may have other commanders and generals, but the main person who leads the fight will usually take the credit for all of them. Just as, if there is a fall, the person will take the fall for all of them.

So, we believe that Ghanaians are unanimous on the 21<sup>st</sup> September, which is the birthday of Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah. Then we have 1<sup>st</sup> Friday in December as Farmers' Day, 25<sup>th</sup> December as Christmas Day for our Christian brothers, and 26<sup>th</sup> December as Boxing Day for our Christian brothers and sisters. Then we have the date for Eid ul-Fitr which varies sometimes because it is a lunar date. So that is for our Muslim community. And then we have the Shaqq day, which we are introducing, that is an additional day for our Muslim community, which is a day after the Eid ul-Fitr. We also have the Eid ul-Adha, which is also lunar. So Mr Speaker, when

we add this, we will see that our number of holidays become 14.

Mr Speaker, we have looked at the practice around us, and we will say that the number is not excessive, we are still within what our neighbours have and the practice around the world. Mr Speaker, many African countries have higher number of holidays. Some of the examples we have are: Madagascar and Uganda, 19 days; Tanzania and Senegal, 18 days; Morocco, 17 days; and Burkina Faso, Egypt, Gambia, Malawi, Niger and Zambia, 16 days.

5.18 p.m.

Then we have Angola, Ivory Coast, Guinea, Mauritius, Rwanda and Tunisia, having 15. Mr Speaker, when you compare this, you see that our number is still lower than all these that we have.

Mr Speaker, one other significant thing that is found in this amendment is that we believe that we need to boost tourism in our country and, Mr Speaker, you notice that some of our holidays happen in the middle of the week. So, we have them Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday. Usually when it happens that way, you see that, the day before or the day after, workers take it for granted. It lowers productivity.

What we intend to do with this amendment is simply to say that if a holiday falls in the middle of the week, that is Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday, it should be observed on a Friday. If it falls on Saturday and Sunday, it should be observed on



Monday, so that there will be some certainty and that gives us longevity in the weekend. That will enhance our tourism and the creative art industry. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Lastly, as demanded by the Public Financial Management Act (PFMA), we did the financial analysis and we realised that, with what we are doing and pushing some of the holidays towards the weekend, it is rather going to even enhance our economic activity and we did not find that, financially, it would affect our country in any way.

Mr Speaker, this is what we have and I hope that Members will support this amendment, so that it will be carried out just as the Committee recommended.

Thank you very much. *[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the Motion has been ably moved. I will call on the Chairman of the Committee on Defence and Interior to present the Report of the Committee on the Bill.

**Chairman of the Committee (Mr James Agalga):** Mr Speaker, I support the Motion ably moved by the Minister for the Interior.

Mr Speaker, in so doing, I would crave your indulgence and submit the Report of the Committee. But Mr Speaker, for the sake of brevity, I would pray that the *Hansard* capture the Report in its entirety while I touch on the salient observations the Committee made.

## 1.0 Introduction

The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025 was presented to Parliament and read the First time by the Hon Minister for the Interior, Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka, on Tuesday, 24<sup>th</sup> June, 2025, in accordance with Article 106 of the 1992 Constitution and Order 159 of the Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana.

The Bill was, subsequently, referred to the Committee on Defence and Interior and the leadership of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs for consideration and Report in accordance with Article 106(4) and (5) and Orders 247 and 165 of the Standing Orders of the House. The Speaker, in accordance with Article 106(13) and Order 160(2), also directed the Committee to determine whether the Bill is of an urgent nature to be taken through all the stages in a day.

Pursuant to the referral, the Committee met with the Hon Minister for the Interior, Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka, and officials of the Ministry of the Interior, and the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice and considered the referral.

The Committee, having carefully examined the referral, hereby, presents this Report to the House in accordance with Article 106(5) and Orders 166 and 215 of the Standing Orders of the House.

The Committee is grateful to the Hon Minister and officials of the Ministry of

the Interior and the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice and Attorney-General for attending upon it and assisting in the deliberations.

## 2.0 Reference

The Committee referred to the following additional documents during its deliberations:

- The 1992 Constitution of Ghana;
- The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana; and
- The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001 (Act 601).

## 3.0 Background

The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001 (Act 601) establishes the statutory framework for the declaration and observation of public holidays and commemorative days in Ghana. As the nation has progressed, the list of public holidays and commemorative days and the method of observance of these holidays have evolved to reflect national priorities and values of the time.

The proposed amendments to Act 601 intend to revise the existing holidays and commemorative days, introduce new holidays and empower the President to declare the Mondays immediately after a Saturday or a Sunday, or the Fridays immediately following a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday as public holidays. The amendments are therefore

intended to promote nationalism, reinstate historical integrity and also promote international best practices in the observation of public holidays. It further seeks to promote national unity and religious impartiality in the country.

The proposed amendment is also in line with the government overall agenda and promise to overhaul the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days regime to ensure equity and the preservation of the nation's history.

There is therefore the need to revise the statutory framework of the holidays and commemorative days observed in the country to reflect the country's values and history. The revision is also meant to ensure religious equity, inclusivity and national development.

## 4.0 Purpose of the Bill

The purpose of the proposed amendment to the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001 (Act 601) seeks to:

- a. introduce an additional holiday, namely the Shaqq day, to be observed a day immediately following the Eid- ul-Fitr holiday each year;
- b. recognise the transition of the country to a republican status in 1960 and provide for the observance of Republic Day on the 1<sup>st</sup> of July as a public holiday and not as a commemorative day;

- c. provide for the removal of the celebration of Founder's Day on 4<sup>th</sup> August as a public holiday and rename Kwame Nkrumah Memorial Day as Founders' Day which is to be celebrated on 21<sup>st</sup> September;
- d. empower the President to, by Executive Instrument, declare the Monday immediately after a Saturday or a Sunday, or the Friday immediately following a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday to be observed as a public holiday where the holiday falls on a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday other than a religious holiday.

## 5.0 Provisions of the Bill

The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025 is divided into Two Clauses and Two Schedules. Clause 1 of the Bill seeks to amend section 3 of Act 601 to empower the President to, by Executive Instrument, declare any other day to be observed as a public holiday instead of a day provided under section 1 of Act 601 where the President is satisfied that it would be inexpedient to observe that day as a public holiday. The clause also empowers the President to, by Executive Instrument, declare a public holiday to be observed on the Monday immediately before a Tuesday, a Wednesday or on Thursday, or on the Friday immediately following a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday, where the public holiday falls on a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday. Under the clause, where a public holiday falls on a Saturday or a Sunday, the President is empowered to,

by Executive Instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Monday immediately after that Saturday or Sunday, or on the Friday immediately before that Saturday or Sunday

Clause 2 amends section 7 of Act 601 by adding on to the definitions of expressions used in the Bill. The First Schedule to Act 601 is amended under clause 3 to expand the list of public holidays by the inclusion of Shaqq Day and Republic Day in the list of public holidays and commemorative days.

The First Schedule to Act 601 is amended under clause 3 to expand the list of public holidays by the inclusion of Shaqq Day and Republic Day in the list of public holidays. The Republic Day was previously observed as a commemorative day. The amendment also revises the name of the Worker's Day holiday to "Labour Day", removes the celebration of Founder's Day on 4<sup>th</sup> August as a public holiday and renames Kwame Nkrumah Memorial Day as Founders' Day which is to be celebrated on 21<sup>st</sup> September.

Under clause 4, the Second Schedule to Act 601 is amended by the removal of Republic Day from the list of commemorative days, leaving African Union Day (25th May) as the only commemorative day.

## 6.0 Justification for the Amendments

The proposed amendments are justified by the need to reform the country's holiday framework in a manner that is inclusive, historically accurate, promotes productivity and makes the holidays regime responsive to

evolving social and cultural dynamics of the country and globally.

## **7.0 Observations**

The Committee, having examined the Bill, made the following observations:

### **7.1 Urgency of the Bill**

Following the presentation of the Bill, the Rt Hon Speaker directed the Committee to determine the urgency of the Bill. The Committee subsequently met and unanimously determined the Bill to be of an urgent nature to be taken through all the stages in one day in accordance with Article 106 (13) of the Constitution and Order 160 (3&4) of the Standing Orders of the House.

The House subsequently adopted the report of the Committee on the urgent nature of the Bill.

### **7.2 Promote International Best Practices**

The Committee observed that the proposed amendments which seeks to empower the president to declare mid-week holidays (except religious holidays) to be celebrated on the Monday or Friday will enhance productivity, reduce disruptions to the work week, reduce absenteeism and promote a better work-life balance.

### **7.3 Religious Equity and Inclusivity**

The Committee noted that the proposed amendment reflects an effort to promote religious equity in the country

by ensuring balanced recognition of diverse religious practices, thereby avoiding partiality toward specific religious groups in the celebration of religious holidays. The introduction of the “Shaqq Day” as a public holiday will allow Muslims who travel to their home regions for the annual Eid celebration to travel back to their various work regions.

## **6.3 Financial Impact Analysis**

The Committee was informed that the implementation of the proposed Public Holidays (Amendment) Bill, 2025 will not require significant additional resources from the State. The additional holiday is expected to increase consumer spending as holidays can boost household spending, particularly in the tourism and hospitality sectors. The Hon Minister informed the Committee that people often take vacations, travel to visit family and friends, or engage in leisure activities, leading to increased demand for goods and services. Again, additional and longer holidays will help in job creation with retail, hospitality and creative arts industries hiring seasonal workers to meet growing demand for services during holidays.

The Committee further noted that public holidays have the potential to stimulate tourism and associated industries, including creative art services, cultural, natural (environmental), restaurants, transport services, accommodation providers, and retail services. The creative arts industry would also greatly benefit from such long holidays. Additional and longer holidays will stimulate household spending and accelerate economic growth.

## 7.0 Amendments

The Committee, after its deliberations proposed the following amendments to the Bill:

- i. Clause 1 – Amendment proposed – sub-clause (2), Delete and replace with

“(2) Where a public holiday provided under section 1 is to be observed on a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday, the President may, by Executive Instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Friday immediately following the Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday”.

- ii. Clause 1 – Amendment proposed – sub-clause (3), Delete and replace with

“(2) Where a public holiday provided under section 1 falls on a Saturday or a Sunday, the President may, by executive instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Monday immediately after the Saturday or Sunday”.

- iii. Clause 3 – Amendment proposed – Delete “Farmer’s Day” and substitute with “Farmers’ Day”.

## 8.0 Conclusion

The Committee has thoroughly examined the Bill and is convinced that the proposed Bill aims at ensuring that

the existing framework for public holidays is fair and consistent with best practices.

The Committee, therefore, recommends to the House to adopt this Report and pass the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025 in accordance with Article 106(13) of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana and Order 160 of the Standing Orders of the House.

Respectfully submitted.

5.28 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, pursuant to Standing Order 127 a full debate shall arise on the principles of the Bill on the basis of the explanatory memorandum and the Report of the Committee.

Hon Member, before taking the debate, let me suspend the House for two minutes.

5.29 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

5.32 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN THE CHAIR]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I thought the Motion to adopt the Report should be seconded. Then we—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** No, at Second Reading? This is Second Reading, so Hon Members, the Floor is now open for debate. The understanding is we are taking two from each Side.

*Question proposed.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Minority Leadership, are we taking two from each Side?

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, it is such an important Bill if we can get four on both Sides—*[Interruption]*—It is very important because they are proposing about four different holidays and, for that matter, at least, Mr Speaker, with respect—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Deputy Majority Whip?

**Ms Cudjoe:** Mr Speaker, please, it should be two from each Side with Leadership, which makes it three.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, it is so important and urgent; so, if four Members have a bite, it should not be a problem. We can do three contributions from each Side plus Leadership, which makes it four.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, Hon Ranking Member, you have the floor.

**Ranking Member of the Committee (Mr Kofi Amankwa-Manu):** Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to speak on this issue.

First of all, Mr Speaker, I want it to be placed on record that nobody from our Side is against any religious grouping having any holiday. To the contrary, we do support. In fact, the promise made to our Muslim brothers was that they were going to be given holidays anytime they celebrated their festivities, that is Eid ul-Adha and Eid ul-Fitr. Here, we have only one holiday being added; that is the *Shaqq*.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister found it very convenient to compare the number of holidays in our country to other countries in Africa. I was expecting the Hon Minister to rather compare our level of productivity because that is what should inform the number of holidays we should get. But as it is, he found it very convenient to just compare the holidays.

Again, Mr Speaker, for me, it is sad that year in, year out, we come to this Chamber and debate the contentious issue of honouring our heroes. A country that does not honour its heroes is not a country worth dying for. No Member in this Chamber, Mr Speaker, can or will underestimate the role played by Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah in our journey for independence. Much the same way, nobody can underestimate the role played by other Ghanaians in our quest for independence.

I believe that we should give honour where honour is due. Yes, Dr Nkrumah played his role; every Ghanaian is so grateful. So are men like Ako Adjei, J. B. Danquah, Ofori Atta, and the rest; they also played a role. Mr Speaker, we are going to celebrate the birthday of Dr Nkrumah. Well, that I believe was a

campaign promise, but I have always maintained that as a country, there should be a time when we come together as a people and look at the collective interest of the generality of the country and not just a section of the country.

So, I am of the view that yes, today, the Founder's Day is being changed from 4<sup>th</sup> August to 21<sup>st</sup> September, which is the birthday of Dr Nkrumah. Are we going to come back to this Chamber when the tables turn to change the day again? *[Uproar]* —Well, Mr Speaker, we can be here today and shout all that we want, but let us have on record that as long as we remain a nation, we will have to honour everybody who contributed to writing the history of this country.

Mr Speaker, a day will come when the history of this Parliament in Ghana will be written. There is no way anybody can take away the role played by the Rt Hon Speaker Alban Bagbin for having been the first Speaker to sit in the Chair when the Government in power was from the opposing Side. Mr Speaker, that will be a history. Nobody can change the history. Today, if Members find it convenient to change the history of this country, a day will come when that history will be rewritten again.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Habib, you have the floor.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I would like to add my voice to this matter before the House. I would also like to state categorically that no one

from the Minority Side is against the holidays or the Bill. Mr Speaker, the argument of our Leader against the urgency of the Bill does not mean he is against the Bill itself. It was clear. When he spoke, he spoke on the principle of the urgency of the Bill under Standing Order 163, but it is not the case that we in the Minority are against the Bill.

Mr Speaker, among many other things on this Bill, I think this is the only part that I will give a 50 per cent commendation to the President of the Republic for fulfilling, at least, a campaign promise. During the campaign, the President of the Republic, His Excellency President John Mahama, said they will add an additional day to Eid. Mr Speaker, we do not have one Eid. We have Eid ul-Fitr and Eid ul-Adha. If we look at the Bill that the Minister for the Interior presented to the House, it only captures another day in addition to the already existing day in the Eid ul-Fitr, but none has been captured in the Eid ul-Adha.

Mr Speaker, yes, the President and the Government must be commended for adding an additional day to Eid ul-Fitr and it is something that I will join my Colleagues in Ghana and the Muslim community to say a very big thank you to the President for doing. But as part of the promise that the President made to Ghanaians, it is incomplete.

Mr Speaker, when you look at the Memorandum of the Bill, there is an attachment from the Secretary of Cabinet to the effect that they are only adding one extra day to Eid al-Fitr. It is not enough.

When the Ministers for the Interior, Education, Environment, Science and Technology are all Muslims and in Cabinet, as well is the Majority Leader, the first Muslim Majority Leader of this Parliament, who knows the importance of Eid ul-Adha —

5. 42 p.m.

Mr Speaker, Eid ul-Adha is so important, to the extent that it is the climax of the fifth pillar of Islam, that is Hajj. The climax of it needs a lot of days. This is the Eid that we slaughter either cows or whatever one can afford. On that very day that one slaughters the cows, the next day, one is arranging things — Mr Speaker, the Minister for Education slaughtered a lot of cows and sheep during this year's Eid ul-Adha. He spent a lot of days to prepare it. Eid ul-Adha is so important to Muslims as Eid ul-Fitr is.

Mr Speaker, when we come to the Consideration Stage, I will propose an amendment and I call on my Colleagues to join me in this amendment. That amendment also seeks to add the *Tashreeq*, which is the day after Eid ul-Adha. Because this amendment, in this current form, intends to add the *Shaaq* day, which is the day before Eid ul-Fitr. So, we can amend it because it is an Act of Parliament and Parliament is within the law to amend it, so that we can add *Tashreeq* to the days, that is the day after Eid ul-Adha. The Muslim community will be happy.

Mr Speaker, the Muslim community wrote to the President, through the Cabinet, to inform him that we will be very happy if he gives us these two extra days for Eid. Yes, the President has fulfilled one and we think that it is very necessary that he adds the other one.

My senior Colleague, Dr Murtala, is a scholar when it comes to many Islamic things and he is a member of Cabinet. I am very surprised that he could not raise this matter at Cabinet. I am very surprised that the Majority Leader could not add his voice on this.

Mr Speaker, Islamic jurisprudence recognises Eid al-Adha as a greater part of the two Eids. Mr Speaker, aligning a public holiday to include an extra day in the Eid ul-Adha will be very significant to the Muslim community. When the President was inaugurating the construction of the Hajj Village, he said, he was adding an extra day to the Eid celebration. So, the Muslim community said Eid means both Eids. That is how the Muslim community is taking it. So, to add only a day to Eid ul-Fitr without adding an extra day to Eid ul-Adha, the Muslim community will think that it is a half promise that is being fulfilled and I want to call on my Colleagues and indicate, that when we get to the Consideration Stage, I will be proposing an amendment to add the *Tashreeq*, to the Eid ul-Adha.

Mr Speaker, the name-changing and the name-calling of the holidays that the Minister for the Interior—to the effect that we are cancelling Founders' Day and introducing President Kwame



Nkrumah's Day, it is definitely not going to be a consensus. If we are talking about Founders' Day, the United Gold Coast Convention (UGCC) is part of it and now we are going to single out an individual, our former President Kwame Nkrumah. But there were other important people who have contributed their quota to the development of this country throughout the struggle for our independence. So, Hon Minister, changing the name will not be by consensus. Changing the name to say that it is going to be called Kwame Nkrumah's Day is something that we are not going to do.

Mr Speaker, I think that the Minister for the Interior should look at it again. Rather than that, we will be changing names and continue to change names and in three and a half years' time, when we sit on the other Side, we will also change the name.

Mr Speaker, I thank you so much.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Dr Murtala?

**Dr Murtala Muhammed Ibrahim (NDC — Tamale Central):** Mr Speaker, I beg to support the Motion.

Mr Speaker, I thought we were going to engage in this debate without some of the political or partisan nuances that we have heard from our Friends. It is true that when we are talking about the political history of this country, we need to talk about it to the fullest. I agree. I did some history from level 100 to 200 at the University of Ghana and I had the privileged opportunity to be taught by no

less a person than Prof Addo-Fenning. And as part of the definitions of history, there are some scholars who have defined history as concocted lies to form facts. I think that there are some scholars—*[Interruption]*— Can I finish? Oh, so Hon Members want the source?

Mr Speaker, they should go and read the SHS history books. They should go and read *Topics in West African History* written by no less a person than Prof Adu Boahen. They should go and read their writings —*[Interruption]*— But what other source do you want?

Mr Speaker, that is the source. So, I think that what we have seen today is a perfect description of why history could be defined as concocted lies to form facts. We have seen that across the aisle, they have focused on that aspect of definition of history which is roundly condemned by many historians. But let me be very clear, the reason we talk about Nkrumah and the reason we talk about the history of this country, we do so because there is always an effort by our Friends from the other Side to rewrite the political history of this country. Need I remind you that even after Nkrumah was illegally and unjustifiably overthrown, Nkrumah's mother, who was over 80 years and barely blind, the woman was dragged to appear before Commission after Commission. And do you know what they wanted the woman to say? They wanted the woman to say Nkrumah was not her biological son. These are historical facts—and that Nkrumah was a Liberian. These are historical facts. Hon Members can check it from the *Hansards* of Parliament. They do not

read and it is not my fault that they do not read. I am saying that Nkrumah's mother was dragged —*[Interruption]*— Mr Speaker, I am given a time —*[Interruption]*— when they were speaking —there is a popular proverb that when you take —

5.52 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Dr Murtala, I will recognise Mr Anyimadu-Antwi.

**Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi (NPP —Asante Akim Central):** Mr Speaker, this matter is very serious and I think my Brother is misleading the House. He cannot go and read any incredible story from anywhere and come and make allegations, wild allegation and there is no source. He was just saying Nkrumah's mother was being coerced into saying that —I have never heard it. Where did he get it from? He should prove it. Prove it and give us a source.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Dr Murtala Muhammed Ibrahim, with all due respect, the debate must be centred on the principles underpinning the Bill and the Committee's Report. So, please stick to the Report and the memorandum underpinning the Bill.

**Dr Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, part of what we are considering today is the Founder's Day and we cannot talk about the Founder's Day of this country without talking about the founder, the only founder of the present-day Ghana. I am saying that the reason why emphasis

is placed on Nkrumah is because there have been several attempts—and when I said she appeared before Commission after Commission, this was not done in some bush somewhere. —*[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Dr Murtala, please, all statements relating to criminality, accordingly, they are expunged from the record.

**Dr Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, — I will make the points in a way.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Mr Nitiwul, are you on point of order? Else, I will give you the floor to speak. What is your point of order?

**Mr Dominic Nitiwul (NPP—Bimbilla):** Mr Speaker, I rise on a point of order based on your ruling the last time. I want to state that my Hon Colleague has the right to debate forcefully, but we should learn from history.

Mr Speaker, we regret what happened the last time. I think we are going back to that same thing again. At least I have been in this House for over 20 years, I will urge that my Colleague does not provoke people to say things that will bring pain to people in this House. It will not be good for people to say things or respond in a manner that will bring pain to people in this House. I beg him to just stay away from it. It would not help anybody. If people want to get up and say things, it will bring a lot of pain to this House. So, I beg him, he should please stay out of it.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Dr Ibrahim Murtala, please withdraw your statement referring to anybody as criminal.

**Dr Ibrahim:** Well, Mr Speaker, everything I said here,

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Dr Murtala kindly withdraw.

**Dr Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, I withdraw. I withdraw, but let me make my points—  
[Uproar]—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, resume your seats!

*[The First Deputy Speaker rises to be heard in silence pursuant to Standing Order 126(3).]*

Hon Murtala Ibrahim, once again, limit yourself to the Memorandum accompanying the Bill and the Report of the Committee.

**Dr Ibrahim:** Mr Speaker, I remember when I was a student at Kulikuli School; Thankfully, my senior brother, Hon Haruna Iddrisu also attended Kulikuli School. On *Eid* day, we were forced to go to school. It took the National Democratic Congress (NDC) to ensure that there was social justice and equity in a country that is constitutionally described as a secular state. The NDC gave us our first holiday as Muslims in this country; Thanks to the NDC.

My brother was telling me by mentioning the number of Muslims at Cabinet. I never knew that Cabinet

Ministers were more influential than Vice Presidents. We had a Vice President who was a Muslim for eight years. He did not see the need. They are now mentioning our names that Hon Haruna Iddrisu, Hon Muntaka, Hon Murtala are Muslims at Cabinet. We had a Vice President yet he did not see the need. This tells the beauty of this country. It tells how accommodating Ghanaians are. It tells why we have become an oasis in turmoil that if you go through social media, everybody points to Ghana and says that this is the country I would want to be in. You would find Muslims attending church programmes, you would find Christians who are attending programmes in mosques as well as traditional worshippers; that makes us a state. But this idea of trying to bring about religious justifications and why you think that as Muslims we should have done that, I leave that to the Ghanaian public who are watching live across the globe.

The NDC has always demonstrated that everybody in this country should be treated equally. And for us as NDC, this particular holiday which is given to us, for me, is a relief. Because I still remember as a little boy attending school, the agony I went through to go to school on *Eid* day when my colleagues were celebrating. We can only thank His Excellency President Mahama and thank the National Democratic Congress.

Mr Speaker, that explains why, even though my grandfather was one of the founding fathers of the United Party (UP) tradition.

The more I read about the political history of this country, the more I gravitate towards the only political party that ensures social justice and equity, and that is the National Democratic Congress. *[Hear! Hear!]*

6.02 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I would conclude by saying, yes, we need to talk about the history of this country. But history is properly told when you acknowledge both the positives and the negatives. Nkrumah is the founder; Nkrumah was a judge—The African of the Millennium not African of ten years or a hundred years. And he was a judge by no less a group than the entire continent of Africa. The British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) voted him as such. Who changed the Founders Day in the first place? Who changed it? What the NDC and President Mahama is seeking to do is to correct the wrongs; wrongs that were emotionally driven. Wrongs that were not driven by social justice and proper candour which is expected of politicians. President Mahama is changing it. So, the threat that what happens to the tables change. When you do that—and hopefully, that will take a very long time. The people of this country—

Mr Speaker, we want to urge our friends, and I agree with Hon Habib Iddrisu when he suggested that there could be addition because of the Eid al-Adha.

I will conclude with a famous proverb in Dagbon that “One cannot sleep with an itching anus and not expect

to wake up with smelling fingers”. They ensured that they slept with an itching anus; It is their baggage to carry. And that is why the frustration is found everywhere in the faces of my Hon good friends.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Suhuyini?

**Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan (NDC — Tamale North):** Well, thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion.

Mr Speaker, I was taken aback when I listened to the Minority Leader and like Pontius Pilate, he sought to disassociate his Side from the decision that this House was about to take in relation to these holidays. Mr Speaker, I would have taken it lightly perhaps if it was coming from one of their colleagues, Hon Stephen Amoah.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Hon Suhuyini, I recognise the Hon Minority Leader.

Yes, Hon Minority Leader, you have the floor.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, for the avoidance of doubt, when I spoke—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Stephen Amoah, what is the problem? When your Leader is up, you are also up?

Please, Minority Leader, you have the floor.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I am right here in this Chamber and I will not sit for any Member of Parliament to attempt an interpretation of what I have said and try to spin it.

Mr Speaker, I rose at a point where the Committee had presented a Report for us to consider this Bill through a certificate of urgency. Mr Speaker, my argument was to the effect that nothing has suddenly arisen for the Minister of the Interior to suddenly invite this House to proceed on that path. Indeed, the Minister has always known that this law existed and if the Government was minded, it would have proceeded ahead of time. I then went on to say that if indeed the Government intends to make priorities, there are promises— socio-economic promises, and I went ahead to list them. So, Mr Speaker, early on, the Majority Leader made a submission. I took it as the usual politics when we talk, sometimes these things happen. But, Mr Speaker, the path the Deputy Minister has taken to suggest that I got up to oppose the Bill is unsupported by my submission. My submission was in opposition to the urgency that he has introduced to say that these things have always been there and that he should have moved on the path far earlier than coming now. And that, if he was—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, on that score, you are right.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** So Mr Speaker, please direct him to do the right thing and not to misquote me. He should not misquote me.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, Hon Suhuyini, we are supposed to debate the principles, the memorandum accompanying the Bill, as well as the Reports.

Please, let us stick to the rules.

**Alhaji S. Alhassan:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for your guidance.

Mr Speaker, I was speaking to the principles. I just thought that I should respond to a few things that he said.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** We have passed the stage of the determination of the urgency or otherwise of the Bill.

**Alhaji S. Alhassan:** Mr Speaker, I take the restating of his position.

Mr Speaker, I take the restating of his position and I will not debate it further. I, however want to also say that I am particularly excited that this Bill will ensure that another holiday is added as we celebrate Eid in this country.

Mr Speaker, it is urgent because only a couple of weeks ago, this nation had to celebrate Eid-ul Adha, and because this Bill had not been considered, the President had to issue an Executive Instrument for that to be done. So, Mr Speaker, to say that he does not see the urgency is to miss the point that this Bill is even late—

6.12 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Suhuyini Alhassan, please be guided. The earlier Motion moved was to determine the urgency or otherwise. After the debate we put a question on that and the Motion was carried. Now, this Motion was for the Second Reading, and at the Second Reading stage, nothing is supposed to happen except debating the principles or rationales accompanying the Bill, as well as the Report of the Committee. So, please.

**Alhaji Alhassan:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am guided. So, the point I need to make is that this is important and is coming at a good time. Mr Speaker, it will ensure that the next Eid celebration will not require the President to issue an Executive Instrument.

It is also particularly important because we have had a situation in this country where in the past, it became politically correct for people to use religion for votes. Unfortunately, they were not able to meet this expectation of Muslims. So, Mr Speaker, I am happy that once again, Ghana is demonstrating that it does not matter what religion one is in.

If a person is chosen as a leader, he or she will act fairly towards all manner of people in this country. This is because as we speak, we have a Christian President and Vice-President who at Cabinet, together with some Muslim Cabinet Ministers decided that this promise had to be fulfilled. And that, for me, is a plus in the furtherance of Ghana

and for our democracy. That should go to the politicians who often campaign based on religious affiliations, so that they can understand that what we need in this country is leadership. That leadership, when it is provided by even a Buddhist, will get that person the support of all Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, however, I would have wished that this particular holiday, even as it is just one, be assigned to Eid-ul-Adha. That is where perhaps, Mr Speaker, I agree with the argument made earlier by the First Deputy Minority Whip that looking at the celebration of Eid-ul-Fitr and Eid-ul-Adha, Mr Speaker, I think that an additional holiday added to Eid-ul-Adha will make more impact than Eid-ul-Fitr. This is a personal observation.

And it is my hope that subsequently, perhaps when an amendment is brought, or when it becomes necessary for a government to consider an additional holiday, we will assign it to Eid-ul-Adha. Mr Speaker, I say so because, yes, both holidays are lunar guided, but Eid-ul-Adha, according to the religion of Islam, takes about three days to celebrate. So, we have the day of prayer and the day of sacrifice. So, Mr Speaker, if we have an additional holiday that is assigned to Eid-ul-Adha, it will cater for the day for sacrifice.

I often liken this to the Christian celebration of Christmas and Boxing Day, where Christmas Day is used to celebrate the birth of Christ and 26<sup>th</sup>, which is Boxing Day, is used to share gifts. It is likened to Eid-ul-Adha in that manner, that on the prayer day, when it is guided by the lunar calendar, we go to

the mosque to pray. The next day is often for sacrifice and that is the day the animal that we sacrifice to share to God and to the neighbours is also done, like Boxing Day.

So, Mr Speaker, it is my suggestion that in future, when we consider another holiday, or when it becomes necessary for us to amend this, we ensure that we shift this holiday from Eid-ul-Fitr to Eid-ul-Adha.

Mr Speaker, I also wish to commend the Government for resetting the celebration of Founders' Day to its original status. Mr Speaker, it is common knowledge that Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah has, over the years, proven all critics wrong and risen above all the damnation, to be accepted globally and internationally as the founder of this nation. And so, it is quite disingenuous that we still have some people who want to undermine the name of Dr Kwame Nkrumah.

Clearly, in every team, it takes the team to achieve results, but there is always a leader. That is why even in the Ghana Black Stars, we will tell you about Abedi Pele and Stephen Appiah; there will always be a captain of a team. It is clear that in our history, Dr Kwame Nkrumah was the captain and deserves that recognition, and when we talk about our founders, he must be the *primus inter pares*. Mr Speaker, with these few words, I thank you very much, and I call on my Colleagues to support the passage of this Bill, so that we can enjoy these holidays, to reflect on the future of this country, and also to reflect on the work

ahead for all of us to do in building this nation. Thank you very much.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you. Yes, Hon Nitiwul?

**Dr Stephen Amoah** — *rose* —

**Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I rise to support—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Stephen Amoah, why are you always up? Yes, Hon Nitiwul, you have the floor.

**Mr Nitiwul:** I thank you, Mr Speaker. I am glad that this has passed, so that his name does not get mentioned again. But Mr Speaker, I rise to support the Motion and also to put on record, as the Minority Leader has already stated, that the urgency of the Bill is what this House spoke about, but the substance of the Bill is good for everybody. That is not to say that we will not raise critical issues for us to discuss as people of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the first critical issue we want to raise is that we have had four republics in our nation's history. The longest-running republic is the Fourth Republic. So, if we really want to celebrate a republic day, which one will we celebrate? We have the First Republic, Second Republic, Third Republic, and this is the Fourth Republic. The longest-running and the most stable has been the Fourth Republic. So, if we really want to celebrate a republic day as a country, which one will we vote for as people? Regardless of the political differences

we have, the debate should not be about emotions, but the debate should be about what is good for the people of Ghana.

6.22 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it is good to give our Muslim brothers another holiday. It is important. They would be able to tell us which one would be better. But the Minister himself is a Muslim, so maybe he has looked at both the Eid-ul-Fitr and Eid-ul-Adha and thought that giving an additional holiday to Eid-ul-Fitr would be better. There are some who believe that it would have been tidier to make Eid-ul-Adha another holiday instead of giving Eid-ul-Fitr two holidays.

But in principle, Mr Speaker, this Side of the House, and I believe the entire House, supports that we should do that. After all, there are two major religions. It is not about the numbers that are involved; it is about the fact that there are two major religions in this world. From our side of the divide, when I say our side, I mean our side of being human beings—If a person goes to China or India and talks about Christians and Muslims, they will not say that they are major religions. But when we come to Africa, there are two major religions; Christianity and Islam. Forget about the numbers. So—*[Interruption]*—No, they are two. Mr Speaker, we have moved beyond traditional religion. There are about some five per cent of Ghanaians who are traditionalists. Nobody is discounting them. But the fact is that there are two major religions.

Mr Speaker, that is the reason if we decide to give both religions holidays, nobody will argue about it. But it is about how, when, and what we use that holiday for.

Thirdly, Mr Speaker, I still want to go back to this issue of Dr Kwame Nkrumah and the Founder's Day.

People have always whipped up sentiments, so in the analysis, they missed a lot of things. In many countries, especially southern African countries, they celebrate the birthday of Kwame Nkrumah and I think that is what Ghanaians should be looking at. That the person who led the independence and got the independence—There were many people who fought for their independence. But the person who ultimately stood and took the independence for this Republic was Kwame Nkrumah. We all know that, so many nations, including Ghana, should be celebrating him. The birthday of Kwame Nkrumah should be made a holiday; nobody is going to be against it. Mr Speaker, let nobody be deceived that the man who gave Kwame Nkrumah money to come down to Ghana did not play a role—**[Some Members of the Majority: Ei!]**—Mr Speaker, let nobody be deceived that Kwame Nkrumah, who took money, paid for—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Nitiwul, you were here when I admonished that, at this particular level, the debate should be centred on the Memorandum and the Report of the Committee.



**Mr Nitiwul:** I will move away from there.

Mr Speaker, I will go back to the Memorandum. I wanted to set some record straight, but I will move away. I will take your advice and move away.

Mr Speaker, I think that it is good to honour our heroes, so honouring Kwame Nkrumah is a very good thing for all of us. And I believe that when we were all kids, we sang the praises of Kwame Nkrumah. Even as adults, we all sang the praises of Kwame Nkrumah and all the people who suffered. We are still honouring everybody. I will honour every one of them who suffered for Ghana, including you, Mr Speaker. We all do that and for me, I will give honour to everybody. But we recognise that Kwame Nkrumah was the one who ultimately stood and we got the independence. So, we will celebrate him on his birthday. That, I agree; I do not have a problem with that.

Mr Speaker, I will say also that it is important to use occasions like this to unite the nation and it must start from this House. It seems any time we get the opportunity to debate our history, we turn out by creating problems for ourselves, rather than uniting the nation. Maybe, it is because of politics; maybe, not. But I can say that we should be very careful. We should be careful because today we are Members of Parliament; tomorrow we are not. Mr Speaker, those who began in 1992, I do not believe anyone is still here. In fact, those who began in 2000, it is only Hon Collins Dauda and one or two are around. Then

we came and joined them along the way before 2004. There are just a few people who are around.

Mr Speaker, the life cycle of the service of a Member of Parliament is very short in Ghana. We should make the little impact we want to make. So, I want to congratulate my Friend, the Minister for the Interior, for bringing this Bill to the House. But I also say to him that, as he seeks to give people more days to enjoy themselves as holidays, let us also find a way of using one of the days, like the commemorative days, to see what we can do as Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, the worst thing anybody can do to himself and the worst thing Ghanaians are doing to ourselves is the fact that we are retrogressing from a nation into tribes and that is the problem that Ghana has. We are retrogressing from being a nation into tribes, so people are more loyal to their tribes today than 10 years ago. People are more loyal to their tribes today than 20 years ago.

Mr Speaker, in fact, 1970s, 1980s and 1990s, people were more loyal to the nation Ghana than today. I thought that, as the nation grows, it should have been changing. So, we use the commemorative days that we have to see what we can do to be able to get Ghana as a country. Holidays are good, yes, but to what end? Trust me, by the time that the news gets out here, it will be talking about how people are fighting over whether Kwame Nkrumah is a founder or not. That is all people will be fighting about. That is what will go out.

6.32 p.m.

But then, the essence of the Bill and the reasons this Bill came will be lost on all of us. We will not be able to get exactly why this Bill came because, at the end of the day, the Memorandum to the Bill spelt out the reasons they need this Bill and why the Minister chose to do two holidays for *Eid-ul Fitr*, instead of another one for *Eid-ul Adha*.

I think that I will look at the Memorandum again and, at the end of this particular debate, maybe, when we come to the Consideration Stage, we will see whether we will propose amendments to this particular Bill or not. I hope that the Minister will understand us when we begin to look at it and see whether there is a chance that we can propose amendments that will meet the Majority. Because, like it or not, they have the numbers to do what they want, but I hope that they will listen to our wisdom as well and then agree when the wisdom comes.

Mr Speaker, have we counted the number of holidays that we have in Ghana? It is fourteen—*[Interruption]*—Are they not many? Mr Speaker, I still say that we should be careful as a state that we do not use history to divide ourselves. It is not necessary. Because if we want to debate about history, there are many things that people are missing and people will get missing. You said we should move away from history, so I will not say it.

But I will conclude by saying that people should go and find out who the

ringleaders of the 1966 coup were and where they came from, and who they are tied to; then they will understand what it is.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, Hon Minority Leader, will you yield to Hon Anyimadu-Antwi?

**Mr Kwame Anyimadu Antwi (NPP — Asante Akim Central):** Mr Speaker, with your leave, I would want to go back to the Report that is under consideration.

Mr Speaker, when we discussed the financial impact analysis, I think what should have been added, and the Minister said it, among other things, is that when we shift the holidays from the middle of the week to a weekend, it brings or promotes productivity. This is omitted. If we are talking about tourism alone, then we must as well say that all vacations—We should forget about everything and do holidays alone; then we could go by tourism. But the Minister said, yes, we are moving this to a weekend and that promotes productivity. Mr Speaker, with your leave, I would want that to be added.

Then, again, at page 7 of the Report — Conclusion — the last sentence after “therefore”, I would want the word “unanimously” to be inserted to read:

“The Committee therefore unanimously recommends to the House to adopt this Report”.

Mr Speaker, finally, there is a point that I would want to draw our attention to. After what has been said by my Colleague, I will associate myself with the Hon Member who spoke lastly. If you look at the Bill itself, the Memorandum to the Bill, how come—I would not—Something came to mind that my paper is lost.

In the Memorandum to the Bill, the Hon Minister had said, and I read the last but one paragraph to the Memorandum:

“...removes the celebration of Founder’s Day, on 4<sup>th</sup> August as a public holiday and renames Kwame Nkrumah Memorial Day as Founders’ Day, which is to be celebrated on 21<sup>st</sup> September.”

Mr Speaker, as a Committee, since we could not correct the Memorandum, I would have thought that we would follow suit with the substance of the Bill. Here we are, a whole debate on where to place an apostrophe, either after “r” or after “s”. Mr Speaker, what are we doing to ourselves as politicians?

There is this House that now, Ghanaians are not sure whether it is called Jubilee House or Flagstaff House. Up till date, this party comes and says it is Flagstaff House, another person comes and says, it is Jubilee House. Can we not settle it? Mr Speaker —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Probably, you would come and say, Anyimadu House.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, on Founder or Founders’ Day, I would have thought that if we can come to a consensus, it is agreed that the 21<sup>st</sup> September would be a day which is the birthday of Kwame Nkrumah. But if we say it is a Founders’ Day, I think we will be doing ourselves good as a nation.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources?

**Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah):** Mr Speaker, let me thank the Minister for the Interior for pushing this through Cabinet and to this House.

Mr Speaker, this Bill effectively corrects historical distortions and sets us on the path to ensure that our children and future generations will get the history of Ghana right. First, the Bill observes the Republic Day on 1<sup>st</sup> July as a public holiday and not a commemorative day. This is very important. That Republic Day is what sets Ghana as truly a country that is truly independent and that can assert itself diplomatically around the world. We cannot talk about Republic Day without understanding what it took to get us that 1<sup>st</sup> July.

Mr Speaker, secondly, the Bill renames Kwame Nkrumah Memorial Day as Founders’ Day. It is often said that history cannot be distorted. Today, what President John Mahama and the NDC is leading this House to do is to set the history of Ghana right. Today, what we are all agreeing is that, yes, we had a lot of leaders who contributed to the

independence of Ghana, but Africa's "Man of the Millennium", the man who has been described as the "Osagyefo" is really the founder of modern Ghana and that is what we are doing today.

6.42 p.m.

Mr Speaker, let me read briefly what the Bill says here and it is clear. It says, it is intended to restore historical integrity and national consensus regarding the leadership of His Excellency Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah in the attainment of the independence of this country. Mr Speaker, I think that on a yearly basis, I have stood on this hallowed ground to call for this day to come, to ensure that we, as a country, will accept collectively, the role of Osagyefo, the man who stands tall, his statue at the AU; the man who galvanised the African continent on the forward march to independence, the man that called Africa for economic emancipation, the journey that was derailed, the reason we struggle today.

Today, we are collectively recalling history and I know Osagyefo will be smiling in his grave that on 21<sup>st</sup> September, the people of Ghana will break and honour his leadership. I know his poor mother, Nyaniba, who was brutally abused and died in pain, will look back —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister, I have admonished —

**Mr Buah:** Mr Speaker, withdrawn.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

**Mr Buah:** Mr Speaker, I think we must all agree that Ghana is finally on the right path in making sure that we correct our history and in correcting our history, we are going to collectively agree that events that led to the independence of Ghana cannot be rewritten by a regime. Those events have been cemented in history and that future governments that will come must learn the lesson that the history of Ghana, the Republic Day and the role of Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah can never be revised and that if we ever try to distort it, Ghanaians will always go back to the true history of Ghana. Today, we collectively honour Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah as the founder of the Republic of Ghana.

I thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

**Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin):** Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to add my voice to the debate on the floor.

Mr Speaker, there is everything good in honouring the heroes of a nation. Proposing a holiday to honour those who have served our country is right. However, Mr Speaker, in this Chamber, I believe what is probably dividing us is how we approach this decision to honour our heroes. I listened to the nostalgic and forceful submissions by my respected Colleague, Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah of Ellembele, and I agree with him on the very strong submissions he made about Nkrumah and I want to adopt the same as though they were mine.

However, Mr Speaker, I have some points of disagreement as to how selective we sometimes appear to be in identifying who our heroes are. Mr Speaker, the independence that we talk about was not just a day's event; it was a process that was initiated by some nationalists, way before the 1900s. My own great-grandfather, Nana Ghartey, a nationalist, was part of the Fante Confederacy. He was part of that movement for self-rule. So, Mr Speaker, the argument that in honouring our heroes, let us look at it collectively, cannot be misplaced. The argument is not to say that the contribution of Nkrumah to history should be washed away. Never, never, and never.

The argument on this Side of the House is that there was a collective effort. What has become of the Nii Boi Sekan, who actually was the brain behind the 1948 awareness or the uprising that led to the Big Six being arrested and detained? What has become of him? Mr Speaker, are we saying those who gave impetus to the whole movement are forgotten heroes?

Mr Speaker, if we continue to look at it from a partisan lens, we will continue to amend our laws on every electoral cycle depending on who wins. But let us pause for a moment. Look at us in this Chamber, our various contributions in our various constituencies and somebody one day comes and says that it is only one particular person who is to be picked out of the lot for recognition. Obviously, some people would express some dissenting views.

So, Mr Speaker, it is not all about those who are for or against Nkrumah. It is about a holistic approach; a nationalistic view of the matter and I think that is where I mount my submissions.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, Minority Leader, are you talking about Nii Kobina Bonney or Nii Adjei?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Yes, Mr Speaker, I have just been aided and I thank the Chair for that. I appreciate it. Mr Speaker, I said diplomacy would be healthy for our relationship. Mr Speaker, people do not know we are a family. They say we are always fighting.

Mr Speaker, the name is Nii Kwabena Bonney. That is the correct name. He was a chief. Was he? —Yes Ofosu, Mr Clerk, I thank you for your industry. History will remember you. Well, Mr Camilo, your crown prince, is saying that he supported the research.

Mr Speaker, Nii Kwabena Bonney, that brave chief from Osu, and of course, the records has it that he was also a businessman. He played a major role. In our various Constituencies, we know what we did and Mr Speaker, not to single out our Member of Parliament for Assin North, we were in his Constituency to campaign. Of course, not for him. Mr Speaker, everywhere we went, every village, and I took note of that. It was not about him, but about what his father did many years ago and people were mentioning his father's name. Mr Speaker, that cannot be taken away from him because that was the history his dad

made by serving his people. In various communities in this country, we know the role that people have played. So, Mr Speaker, on the score of recognition, I do not think that we should limit ourselves. We should acknowledge our founders as a collective. That is my view.

Mr Speaker, on the issue of celebrating our brothers who are of the Islamic faith, Mr Speaker, as Hon Nitiwul submitted, two main religions are being recognised by us as a nation. Although, in Ghana, we say we are largely Christians and Muslims, I know that we are also deep-rooted in our tradition and many Ghanaians still believe in the Traditional Religion, but that is for another day.

6.52 p.m.

Mr Speaker, honouring them with a holiday will not be a thing that I will oppose. We have to honour, but Mr Speaker, we would also have to pay attention to certain obligations imposed upon us by the Constitution. Mr Speaker, if you read Article 24, it talks about economic rights. Article 25 talks about educational rights. Article 27 is about women's rights and Article 28 is about children's rights.

Mr Speaker, for the purpose of this submission, I would want to argue with all the force in me that whereas we are desirous of coming out with these holidays through such enactment to honour those with different faith, we must equally focus on how we can empower our people, even as we give them the opportunity to enjoy the benefits of their faith.

Mr Speaker, in the end, if our Muslim brothers and sisters are impoverished, how would they even enjoy the holiday we are giving them? I would encourage that beyond this, let us create economic empowerment tools for them in the various Zongo communities, in the various communities where the Muslim community is very much populated. We should go beyond this and support them because our Muslims women are suffering. Our children from Muslim homes where poverty is denying them the opportunity to have the better part of life, we should channel resources to support these communities. We should not treat it as belated priorities. It should be part of the very governance because Mr Speaker, if we do not do this, we may be deviating from our *raison d'être* because we have a mandate not only to provide the comforts, the holidays, but the mandate primarily also deals with giving an opportunity for the realisation of economic rights.

Mr Speaker, the poverty levels in the country are beyond imagination. The unemployment is a burden to all of us. We have a duty as a people. Even us, we have these holidays: we are recognising Founder's Day; we are adding on to holidays; we are amending. While we see these as a priority, let us also be mindful of what the Constitution enjoins us to do. Equal opportunities for those who have graduated from our schools, the many youths who are looking forward to employment in both the public sector and the private sector. As a political class, we should also tell ourselves, what can we do to create an enabling environment in the private sector for businesses to thrive

so that they can take on more and more of our people who are unemployed. For me, that is the burden of this call. That is the burden of my call. That is the burden of the call of this Side of the House. So that in the end, while we enjoy our holidays, we will finish and go back to work, we will finish and know that we have also been economically empowered and not just been given a holiday.

Mr Speaker, without more, I would want to thank you for the opportunity, thank Colleagues for their indulgence, and say that the Minister may in the end, pursue his Bill, but he should take all that we have said into consideration. Other Ministers whose jurisdictions are related to some of the economic rights issues we have raised must also take this sentiment of the House on board and without delay, introduce the appropriate legislations that will lead to the realisation of the dreams of our people.

Mr Speaker, I shall thank you and resume my seat.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Let me thank the Minister for the Interior for bringing this Bill and taking it under a certificate of urgency so that we can expeditiously approve it and have the President give his assent.

Mr Speaker, I will be very brief. There has been this debate about Eid ul-Fitr and Eid ul-Adha. If we are adding one day to Eid ul-Fitr, why are we not adding one day to Eid ul-Adha?

Mr Speaker, people have forgotten that year after year, we have always had a situation where some sections of the Muslim community will celebrate their Eid on a holiday and another section will celebrate it on a working day. That has been a problem for so many years. Even when the Muslim community was given a holiday to mark the Eid, what usually happened was that because the determination of the day is based on sighting of the moon, one Muslim leader will say that he has not sighted the moon yet, and because he has not sighted the moon yet, he will not pray on the day that Government has designated as the holiday for the celebration of the Eid. So, he will make his congregation observe the Eid on a different date from the rest of the Muslim community and that different date, unless it is a weekend, invariably falls on a weekday. So that section of the Muslim community will be compelled to observe Eid on a working day. So, it became inconvenient. In the case of Eid ul-Fitr, it is indeed appropriate that we create that allowance where it is two days and we can play with the dates and allow all sections at least to have a longer period within which to celebrate. So, I endorse this vision.

In addition, it also came at the end of 30 days, sometimes 29 days of fasting and the last 10 days of extensive midnight prayers.

The Muslim community got very exhausted at the end of it. And the last day, upon very short notice of sighting the moon, we had to expeditiously put in place a programme to be able to observe the Eid and the celebrations. So that,

again, has been very inconvenient. So, His Excellency, President John Dramani Mahama, while campaigning and on the entreaties of Muslim leaders, did promise that when the NDC comes into office, we will add one additional day to take care of these inconveniences and the nature of *Eid al-Fitr*, which makes it commendable to have an additional holiday for that.

Of course, I am not opposed to adding another day for *Eid al-Adha*, just as we have for Boxing Day when it comes to the celebration of Christmas. Because we have Easter, which will be a holiday. And yet, at Christmas, we also have a Boxing Day in addition to Christmas Day. But let us move progressively as a country, one step at a time.

So, I entreat Members, we as Muslims have toyed with the idea of even amending it in this House to forcefully add a second day for *Eid al-Adha*. But we are holding back in order that we build national consensus on these matters. So, I urge colleagues who have been coming to whisper to me and pleading that why do we not just do it once and for all, add another day, that these matters require building national consensus, extensive consultation among the major religious leaders.

One does not just get up and impose a national holiday without consulting the Catholics, the Presbyterians and the different sections of the Muslim community. One cannot just sit in Parliament and impose a day. So, I urge colleagues to be restrained. Let us take what we have now, which is just one additional day for *Eid al-Fitr*.

The second principle in forming this Bill is the mismanagement of holidays. When a holiday occurs and it is a Thursday, automatically, Ghanaians will appropriate the Friday and add it. And on Wednesday, we would do a half day. Same way, if a holiday is supposed to be, let us say, a Wednesday, then it is a problem. So, to give the President latitude to manage the country in such a way that we could more efficiently manage our holidays, we are introducing a provision in our law that says that if a holiday has a day between it and the weekend, then the President has the discretion of instead of allowing it to be observed midweek, to move it to the day before the weekend so that one can have a long weekend. The long weekend enables efficiency; it gives people the opportunity to actually go on a long vacation, travel, meet families and *et cetera*. So, it is this efficiency in the utilisation of holidays that is necessitating the second set of provisions in the Bill.

7.02 p.m.

The last one, of course, does not come without controversy. And I think that we are all free to engage in the political banter that I see happening in the Chamber. No one can ever resolve that matter between us in this country. Because people will try as much as they can to extol the virtues of Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah and define him as the founder of this country; the founder of the nation. Others who equally played a role will continue to make an effort to position themselves. Many of them are no longer there, but their children and



grandchildren will put up a fight. That is perfectly understandable.

But the facts of history remain the facts of history. So, I urge colleagues to accept this Bill to go through the Second Reading so that we can move to the Consideration Stage, and we can pass this legislation without much controversy.

Mr Speaker, I thank you and I urge Members to vote in favour of this Motion.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you, Hon Majority Leader.

*Question put and Motion agreed to.*

The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025, accordingly read a Second time.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader. Do we take the item numbered 19?

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** Rightly so, Mr Speaker, item 19.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we now move to item 19 on the Order Paper at page 5. The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025—Consideration Stage.

## **BILL—CONSIDERATION STAGE**

### **Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025**

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Chairman of the Committee.

Clause 1 – Section 3 of Act 601 amended.

**Mr James Agalga:** Mr Speaker, amendment proposed. Sub clause 2, *delete* and *insert* “2, where a public holiday provided under section 1 is to be observed on a Tuesday, a Wednesday, or a Thursday, the president may by Executive Instrument declare the public holiday to be observed on the Friday immediately following the Tuesday, Wednesday, or Thursday.”

Mr Speaker, the justification for the proposed amendment is that the two clauses that are found in the Bill appear to be repetitive, and so after deliberations, the Committee came to the conclusion that we *delete* clause 1 and simply replace the entire clause with clause 2.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, what will be the new rendition?

**Mr Agalga:** Clause 1, So we would now *delete* and replace the entire clause with 2. And so, the quotation we find is what ought to be captured as 2.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, which one are you deleting and which one are you replacing?

Yes, Hon Minister?

**Alhaji Muntaka:** Mr Speaker, what my Chairman is trying to simply say is that in section 1(2), after the word “the”, continue with “...Friday immediately following that Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday”, and then *delete* the entire (a) and (b), so that the new rendition will now be:

“Where a public holiday provided under section 1 is to be observed on a Tuesday, a Wednesday or a Thursday, the President may, by executive instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Friday immediately following that Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday.”

This will be the new rendition and the simple reason is that, at the Committee, we agreed that this holiday should be earned before it is observed. So, for example, if there is a holiday on Tuesday and we try to bring it on a Monday, that means we are enjoying the holiday before it is really earned. We should rather enjoy it after the day. So if the holiday is on Tuesday, we should enjoy it after that Tuesday, so that we push it to Friday. If it is also on Saturday and Sunday, we should enjoy it on a Monday. We should earn it first before we enjoy it.

So, that warranted that, if that is the case, we *delete* both (a) and (b) in sub-section 2, so that we will then add “...Friday immediately following that Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday” after “the” in line three of sub-section 2. That is the sense of the amendment. Mr Speaker thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Mr Anyimadu-Antwi?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Yes, Mr Speaker, I support the proposed amendment. As has been explained by the Minister and as we have it, the substituted holidays, sub-clauses 1 and 2 were divided into two, and we are doing away with the (a) and (b), and then we will

substitute it with “...Friday immediately following that Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday.” So, as requested, the new rendition would be:

“Where a public holiday provided under section 1 is to be observed on a Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday, the President may, by executive instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Friday immediately following that Tuesday, Wednesday or Thursday.”

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, Hon Members, the proposal is to *delete* clause 1(2)(a) and make (b) part of clause 2.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 2 — Section 7 of Act 601 amended.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, sub-clause 3, *delete* and *insert*, “Where a public holiday provided under section...”

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, your proposal is to clause 1(3)?

**Mr Agalga:** Sub-clause 3.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Of clause 1?

**Mr Agalga:** Yes.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

**Mr Agalga:** So, *delete* and replace with:

“(2) Where a public holiday provided under section 1 falls on a Saturday or a Sunday, the President may, by executive instrument, declare the public holiday to be observed on the Monday immediately after the Saturday or Sunday.”

Mr Speaker, the rationale—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, Hon Member, the proposal is to *delete* all and the whole of the (b)?

**Mr Agalga:** Yes.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** And then make the rest of the (a) part of the substantive clause 3?

**Mr Agalga:** That is so.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

Yes, Mr Anyimadu-Antwi?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, I second the proposed amendment that has been made by the Chairman.

Mr Speaker, the effect of this is for us to have bank holidays, so that the holidays would fall—If it is a Saturday, we will enjoy the Saturday, Sunday, then Monday will be added. We will then have the bank holidays as we have had

previously. We will have it on Friday, Saturday and Sunday. So, I support the proposal made by the Chairman.

Thank you.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, clause 3, *delete* —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Clause 3?

**Mr Agalga:** Yes.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Then let me put a question on the whole Clause 1.

*Question put and Motion agreed to.*

Clause 1 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** I think the next amendment is another sub-clause. So, if we can finish that and put that together.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is why I am asking whether it is clause 3, or —

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** There is sub-clause 1 which we did not amend. Then sub-clause 2, sub-clause 3 and now, he is proposing sub-clause 4.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Chairman of the Committee, please, because the

proposed amendments are not advertised, you must specifically mention the item that you are seeking to amend. This is because you said you are amending Clause 3, suggestive of the fact that there is no advertised amendment on clause 2. Clause 2 is not being amended. That is why I have decided to put the Question on the entire clause 1, as variously amended.

Do you still have amendment on clause 1?

**Mr Agalga:** No, Mr Speaker, we do not.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi, which sub-clause is under amendment?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, I thought that he is now on sub-clause 4, according to the original Bill, which is talking about the Eid-ul-Fitr —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Is there any advertised amendment on sub-clause 4?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** That is where the *Shaqq* Day is to be added.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, what then will be a new rendition to sub-clause 4?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, I think with your leave—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Sub-clause 4.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** It reads: “Sub-section 2 does not ...”, but we do not have sub-sections 2 and 3. It should be:

“Sub-section 2 does not apply to the observance of the following days as public holidays...”

And then the days are listed. We have added *Shaqq* Day. So, we have to list them all as (a), (b), (c), (d), and (e) and that is what— So, if Mr Chairman would not object, I would move that the amendments that we are proposing is to add the *Shaqq* Day to the sub-clause.

7. 12 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, what are you deleting and adding *Shaqq* Day? Or where do you want the *Shaqq* Day to be inserted?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, let me find out from the Minister because a proposal was made that the *Shaqq* Day is being introduced afresh. So, I would have thought that looking at the original Bill, we will now add on. It should be a proposal to add the *Shaqq* Day. But if that has been already taken care of, then I rest my case.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, if we read clause 3(3), the public holidays envisaged

do not include religious holidays and that is what the clause 4 seeks to achieve.

So, you will find that under clause 4(a) to (e), all the festivals listed are religious festivals, so an exception has, therefore, been created.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, so what is wrong with the rendition in clause 1(4)?

**Mr Agalga:** There is absolutely nothing wrong. That is why I am of the view — And I crave the indulgence of my Colleague to allow the proposed amendment to stand as it is.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Mr Anyimadu-Antwi, it is your proposal to *delete* “does” and replace it with “shall”, so that the new rendition will be:

“Sub-section (2) shall not apply to the observance of the following days as public holidays”.

Is that your proposal?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, there is something that the Committee had not considered that I even want to draw the attention of the Minister to.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Please, let us finish with the clause 4.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, to the extent that we have not introduced the *Shaqq* Day and then we are bringing it in a *proviso*, I am not very careful because we have not introduced it at all and I thought we could find a way of introducing it before we can bring it as

an exception. But I was thinking through —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Mr Anyimadu-Antwi, clause 1 of the Bill contemplates public holidays. What sub-clause (4) is seeking to do is that the sub-section (2), which is introducing the public holidays, does not apply to the observance of the following days in a public holiday: The Eid ul-Fitr, *Shaqq* Day, Eid ul-Adha, Christmas Day, and Boxing Day.

**Mr James Agalga:** The provision which creates the *Shaqq* Day as a public holiday is contained in the Schedule.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 1 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move clause 3, *delete* “Farmers”—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, if you do not have any advertised amendment on clause 2, we will take clause 2.

Hon Chairman, please, on record, you do not have any advertised amendment to clause 2.

**Mr Agalga:** That is so, Mr Speaker, we do not have any advertised amendment on clause 2.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, is any other Member having a

proposed amendment to clause 2 of the Bill?

Clause 2 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

Clause 3 — First Schedule to Act 601 amended.

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, clause 3, *delete* “Farmer’s Day” and *insert* with “Farmers’ Day”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Chairman of the Committee, can you specifically point at what you are amending in clause 3?

**Mr Agalga:** [*Inaudible*] which gives us a list of the public holidays in Ghana; it is on page 6.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Under the circumstances, I direct the drafters to tidy it up.

**Mr Agalga:** So, we have —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I have already directed the drafters to tidy it up.

**Mr Agalga:** Very well.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Any other amendments?

*Question proposed.*

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, I beg to support the amendment proposed by the Chairman.

Mr Speaker, the only thing is what you have already corrected which is the fact that we have jammed up the clauses and this is for the draftsman to correct. But so far as we have — So he is correcting the “Farmer’s”; then the apostrophe would go after the “s” so that we have “Farmers’” in plural.

Mr Speaker, on that same clause, let us take it one after the other. When we are done, I may want to have a proposed amendment.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes? Ranking member.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, as we have already said, on the Founder’s Day, I would want to propose that the apostrophe after the “r” be placed after the “s” because we have argued that we need to settle this once and for all. And then we will know that the 21<sup>st</sup> September, which is the birthday of Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah, would be for founders of Ghana.

I so propose.

*Question proposed.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, I think it is proper for us to be captured on record as opposed to the proposed amendment.

Mr Speaker, this is a matter that was thoroughly and exhaustively deliberated upon, whether “Founders” should come with an apostrophe or not and we came to a conclusion that it ought not to be an amendment.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, are you opposed to the amendment?

Very well.

I will have to put a question on the proposed amendment unless he wants to stand it down.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, I do not intend to. I had already argued that the Memorandum to the Bill supports the argument that I have raised.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, let me put the Question on your amendment.

*Question put and amendment negated.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, I then put a Question on the whole clause 3.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 3 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 4 is ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Long title — An ACT to amend the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act 2001 (Act 601) to provide for Shaqq Day and the 1<sup>st</sup> day of July as statutory public holidays and for related matters.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, on record, there is no proposed amendment to the Long Title.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the Long Title is for the consideration of the House—The Motion has been arrested.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, sorry that my attention was not drawn to this. Mr Speaker, I want us to consider the Long Title. I think that we do not have to include the *Shaqq* day as part of the Long Title.

I beg to move that the long title should read:

“An ACT to amend the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001 (Act 601) and to provide for ...” *[Pause]*

Just that the “Shaqq” and the “1<sup>st</sup> July” should be out. So, it should read:

“An ACT to amend the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days as public holidays and for related matters.”

I so propose.

This is because there are a lot of holidays and none of them are being introduced, but to get the *Shaqq* in the Long Title, when we have already included it in the Bill, I do not see the relevance of making it part of the Long Title. That is my proposal.

7.22 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the proposal is to *delete* “Shaqq Day and the 1<sup>st</sup> day of July”.

Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker, I am opposed to the proposed amendment and my reason is that in legislative drafting, the essence of the Long Title is to provide sufficient information to any ordinary reader who grabs a copy of an Act. The person should know straight away on the face of the Long Title what the Act or Bill is all about.

Mr Speaker, we would find that the amendment to the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act is fine, but the addition of the “Shaqq Day” is a novelty and, therefore, must find expression in the Long Title. If it does not, the average reader would have to comb through the entire Bill before he actually understands what its import is.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Chairman of the Committee, can we together look at clause 1(4) which reads:

“Subsection (2) does not apply to the observance of the following days as public holidays:

- (a) Eid-ul-Fitr (Ramadan);
- (b) Shaqq Day;”

Hon Minister, what do you say to this?

**Alhaji Muntaka:** Mr Speaker, as we all know, there is a drafting style and the Long Title is to give a gist of what we have done or a summary of what has happened. If we look at the craft of this amendment to this Public Holidays and Commemorative Days Act, 2001, the most significant thing about it is the addition of the *Shaqq* and the 1<sup>st</sup> July. So, to taking it out of the Long Title will defeat the drafting style that we are all familiar with. Also, it being there does not hurt anything.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, do we take it out from clause 1(4)?

**Alhaji Muntaka:** No, clause 1(4) is now the details of what we have done, but the Long Title just gives us a summary at a glance: what is the essence of this amendment? It is to add this to this. So, Mr Speaker, it being there does not harm anything and I want to suggest to the Ranking Member that to be able to make progress, let us just leave it.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Ranking Member?

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Mr Speaker, I have made the point and I want us to enrich the test and this would have to withstand the test of time. Mr Speaker, I respect you when it comes to drafting.



You are a drafter and a good one, so I seek your guidance on this.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. I would urge you to drop the amendment, so that I put the Question.

**Mr Anyimadu-Antwi:** Very well, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the amendment is withdrawn.

*Question put and Amendment agreed to.*

Long Title ordered to stand part of the Bill.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we have come to the end of the Consideration Stage of the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

Hon Members, we will take the Motion numbered 21.

Minister for the Interior, you may now move the Motion numbered 21.

### **BILL — THIRD READING**

#### **Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025**

**Minister for the Interior (Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka) (MP):** Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025, be now read the Third time.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Motion moved, any seconder?

**Chairman of the Committee on Defence and Interior (Mr James Agalga):** Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Motion moved and seconded and it is for the consideration of the House.

**Mr Agalga:** Mr Speaker?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes?

**Mr Agalga:** There is no advertised—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** For Motion for the Third Reading, we do not advertise it.

**Mr Agalga:** Yes, so I am saying there is none. This information is key for—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is why I said, “Motion moved and seconded; it is for the consideration of the House.”. So, if any Member, probably, before the moving of the Motion, wants the Bill to be taken through a Second Consideration Stage, then the Member may rise on his feet.

*Question put and Motion agreed to.*

The Public Holidays and Commemorative Days (Amendment) Bill, 2025—*read the Third time and passed.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Second Deputy Majority Whip?

**Mr Acheampong:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker—

7.32 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, before you come in, I have this announcement to make.

## ANNOUNCEMENT

### Inauguration of Parliamentary Friendship Associations

Hon Members, the Rt Hon Speaker of Parliament will, on Friday 27<sup>th</sup> June, 2025, inaugurate 42 Parliamentary Friendship Associations duly recognised in the Ninth Parliament in the Chamber of Parliament at 9 a.m.

Members of the Diplomatic Corps of countries of the respective Friendship Associations have been invited to the ceremony and are expected to be seated by 8.40 a.m. In this regard, Hon Members are entreated to be also seated by 8.40 a.m.

Thank you for your audience.

Yes, Second Deputy Majority Whip?

**Mr Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, we skipped the Questions numbered 92 and 237, which are directed to the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts. The Minister is still with us if Colleagues are minded to ask those Questions.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

Hon Members, I recall we varied the order of Business without taking the Questions numbered 92 and 237. The Hon Minister is now here.

May we now take the Question numbered 92, standing in the name of Hon Frank Yeboah, Atwima Nwabiagya North Constituency.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

## ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

### MINISTRY OF TOURISM, CULTURE AND CREATIVE ARTS

#### Revamping and Promotion of Tourist Sites in the Atwima Nwabiagya North Constituency

**Mr Frank Yeboah (NPP — Atwima Nwabiagya North):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the plans of the Ministry to revamp and promote tourist sites at Barekese Dam, Owabi Dam and the Wildlife Sanctuary which have immense eco-tourism potential but suffer low patronage and limited infrastructure in the Atwima Nwabiagya North Municipality.

Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister, you have the floor.

**Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts (Ms Abba Dzifa Gomashie) (MP):** Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to respond to this important Question regarding the tourism potential of Barekese Dam, Owabi Dam and the Owabi Wildlife Sanctuary in the Atwima Nwabiagya North Municipality.

Mr Speaker, the Barekese Dam, situated on the Offin River, is one of the key eco-tourism assets in the Ashanti Region. It supplies approximately 80 per cent of potable water to Kumasi and its environs. Constructed between 1965 and 1969, the original project included components for both water supply and hydroelectric power generation; however, the power generation aspect was not implemented. The dam is currently managed by the Ghana Water Company Limited.

Similarly, the Owabi Dam, Ghana's oldest operational dam which dates back to 1928 and was upgraded in 1954, holds immense historical and ecological significance. Initially designed to supply 3 million gallons of water per day, it now provides approximately 1.56 million gallons daily. The dam, along with the Owabi Wildlife Sanctuary, forms part of a Ramsar site and it is rich in biodiversity. The sanctuary boasts of 161 bird species, Mona monkeys, African civets, and various butterfly species, making it an ideal destination for eco-tourism activities such as birdwatching, boating, and recreational fishing. The Wildlife Sanctuary is managed by the Wildlife Division of the Forestry Commission, while the dam remains under the purview of the Ghana Water Company Limited.

Despite their immense potential, these sites suffer from inadequate infrastructure and limited publicity, leading to low patronage.

Mr Speaker, in recognition of the eco-tourism potential of these sites, the

Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts (MoTCCA), through its implementing Agency, the Ghana Tourism Authority (GTA), is taking strategic steps to revitalise and promote the Barekese and Owabi tourism enclaves through the following:

### **1. Stakeholder Collaboration**

The Ministry plans to work in close partnership with key stakeholders, including Traditional Authorities, Community Leaders, the Atwima Nwabiagya North Municipal Assembly, Ghana Water Company Limited, and the Wildlife Division of the Forestry Commission. This collaborative effort aims to ensure shared ownership, sustainable management, and local participation in the development of the sites.

### **2. Sensitisation and Promotion**

A vigorous sensitisation and marketing campaign will be launched to raise awareness and drive visitor numbers. This will include the production and dissemination of promotional materials such as brochures, flyers, and leaflets; digital content for websites and social media platforms; and targeted outreach to youth groups, students, and faith-based organisations, among others.

### **3. Tour Packaging**

The Ministry, through the GTA, will collaborate with the Tourism Society of Ghana (TOUSOGHA) and the Tour Operators Union of Ghana (TOUGHGA) to package educational tours and excursions to these destinations,

positioning them as key attractions for domestic tourism.

#### 4. Infrastructure Development

The Ministry, in partnership with the Ministry of Roads and Highways, will prioritise the improvement of access roads leading to the Barekese Dam and Owabi Dam, the Wildlife Sanctuary and many other areas. Additionally, efforts will be made to rehabilitate and upgrade basic visitor facilities, including tourist information centres, sanitary facilities, parking areas, and nature trails.

#### 5. Recreational Enhancements

Recreational infrastructure such as picnic spots, viewing platforms, and guided tour services will be introduced to enrich the visitor experience to encourage repeat visits.

#### 6. Conclusion

Mr Speaker, the Ministry is committed to unlocking the tourism and economic potential of Barekese and Owabi. We believe that with improved infrastructure, strategic promotion, and community engagement, these sites can contribute significantly to regional development, job-creation, and environmental conservation.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

**Mr Yeboah:** No further questions, Mr Speaker.

Thank you very much and thank you, Hon Minister.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. This is a constituency-specific in relation to Atwima Nwabiagya North Municipality.

Well, I will give you the opportunity.

**Mr John Darko:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker —Yes, he said I can go ahead with my question. I thank the Hon Minister for her Answer. She said that the Ministry would collaborate with TOUSOGHA and TOUGHHA to package some educational tools. Is she able to tell this House where the Ministry is in their collaboration with these people? Have they started? Which part of the collaboration stage are they now?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Ms Gomashie:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. If the Hon Member of Parliament will recall, during my vetting, I indicated that I was interested in domestic tourism and positioning myself to champion that. Subsequently, I have met with the industry players and espoused this to them. It is my hope that they will take it up.

But most importantly, I have also asked the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to give me the opportunity to meet the Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs) so

that I sell this to them because each district or municipality must own what they have. When we have supported them to promote it, the revenue that comes stays within their community. So, they must be interested in how they develop what they have. So, it is work in progress. We have not concluded. We are still having conversations around it.

7.42 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you. We then move to the Question numbered 237, standing in the name of Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah, Member of Parliament for Offinso North.

### **Rehabilitation of Six Forts and Castles across the Country**

**Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North):** Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the plans of the Ministry on the recent allocation of GH¢22 million for the rehabilitation of six forts and castles across the country.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister?

**Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts (Ms Abba Dzifa Gomashie) (MP):** Mr Speaker, it is recalled that Ghana was among the first countries in 1975 to ratify the UNESCO Culture Convention on the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage — 1972 (also known as the World Heritage Convention). Following the ratification of the World Heritage Convention, Ghana successfully listed its Forts and Castles on UNESCO's

prestigious World Heritage List (WHL) in 1979.

Over the years, UNESCO has assisted Ghana in protecting the Forts and Castles World Heritage Property (FCWHP) through several interventions. Despite this support, the property continues to deteriorate; due to lack of financial resources to ensure adequate conservation and management systems.

Mr Speaker, in 2024, a UNESCO Retroactive Monitoring Mission to Ghana reported that the historic sites faced preservation challenges due to their age and exposure to the elements, which could lead to deterioration, damage, or even loss of their cultural treasures. Indeed, the problem of weakening structural integrity at almost all the sites was observed. To address this situation, the need for the Ghana Museums and Monuments Board to be granted financial and technical clearance to embark on a restoration process was emphasised.

As a result, in November 2024, the Ministry of Finance was directed by Cabinet to release a total sum of GH¢22 million but was carried forward into the year, 2025, as a commitment for the restoration of some of the historic sites. These are: Fort Saint Anthony, Fort Orange, Fort Appollonia (in the Western region), Ussher Fort, James Fort and Christiansburg Castle (in Accra).

Mr Speaker, as we speak, the contracts for the restoration process have been signed and contractors, subsequently, granted access to the sites, except for the Christiansburg Castle which the Ministry is yet to be given access to. It is, therefore, expected that, work on the

afore-mentioned Forts and Castles will be completed within the next eight and 12 months.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

**Dr Asamoah:** Mr Speaker, I will cut it down to one. I would like to ask the Hon Minister, will this restoration project include interpretive materials, visitor facilities and digitalisation of the documents for our heritage sites? And how well are the local communities included in this restoration project? Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Two in one question.

Hon Minister?

**Ms Gomashie:** Mr Speaker, let me say that before the contractors are given the opportunity to work on these sites, the expectation is that they would have engaged the community to see what other things should be added. All these works were done in 2024 and I believe that the contractors would adhere to what the findings were and execute the project satisfactorily for the benefit of our country.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Asamoah, any further questions?

**Dr Asamoah:** Thank you, Mr Speaker, and Thank you, Hon Minister.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minister, we thank you so much for coming to respond to questions related to your Ministry. You are hereby discharged.

Yes, 1<sup>st</sup> Deputy Majority Whip?

**Ms Cudjoe:** Mr Speaker, we have exhausted the day and I move that this House be adjourned to tomorrow at 2 p.m. but Hon Members would like to know the date for the inauguration of the Friendship Association.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** By the memo, it is Friday, 27<sup>th</sup> June.

Hon Members, Motion moved for the adjournment of the House. Any seconder?

**Mr Shaib:** Mr Speaker, we are not opposed to the Motion.

We have actually done more than five hours.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, I am told we have done more than five hours, so you are entirely in my hands.

Then I will proceed to accordingly adjourn the House.

Hon Members, the House is accordingly adjourned until Thursday, the 26<sup>th</sup> day of June 2025 at 2 o'clock in the afternoon.

## ADJOURNMENT

*The House was adjourned at 7.48 p.m. till Thursday, 26<sup>th</sup> June, 2025 at 2.00 p.m.*

